

GUIDELINES FOR THE PREPARATION OF REPORTS BY MEMBER STATES ON THE APPLICATION OF THE 1960 CONVENTION AND RECOMMENDATION AGAINST DISCRIMINATION IN EDUCATION

Preparation of the 11th Consultation

Combating discrimination in education

Eleventh consultation of Member States on the application of the Convention and the Recommendation against Discrimination in Education (1960) (2024-2025)

GUIDELINES FOR THE PREPARATION OF REPORTS BY MEMBER STATES ON THE APPLICATION OF THE 1960 CONVENTION AND RECOMMENDATION AGAINST DISCRIMINATION IN EDUCATION

1. Introduction

The Convention against Discrimination in Education (“the Convention”) and the Recommendation against Discrimination in Education (“the Recommendation”), adopted by UNESCO’s General Conference in 1960, are aligned with UNESCO’s constitutional mandate to “advance the ideal of equality of educational opportunities without regard to race, sex or any distinctions, economic or social”. The Convention is the first legally binding international instrument focused on the **right to education** and the only one exclusively dedicated to it.

The right to education is one of the key principles underpinning the Education 2030 agenda and Sustainable Development Goal 4 (SDG4) adopted by the international community in 2015. SDG 4 seeks to ensure the full enjoyment of the right to education as fundamental to achieving sustainable development. Its scope captures the multidimensional nature of the right to education.

Representing a powerful tool to advance SDG 4 by ensuring effective articulation between normative and operational work, the Convention has been recognized as a cornerstone of Education 2030 agenda.

The present Guidelines are intended to assist Member States in the preparation of country reports on the implementation of the Convention and the Recommendation in the context of the 11th consultation.

2. Scope of the Consultation

Considering the Education 2030 agenda, the monitoring of the Convention and the Recommendation is of crucial importance to ensure an education that is truly inclusive for all and to counter persistent inequalities in access, participation and learning outcomes at all levels, particularly for the most vulnerable groups. This is particularly true under the current context in which countries are making efforts to recover from the learning disruption caused by the COVID-19 pandemic. Concrete measures taken by countries in accordance with their legal obligations under these instruments contribute to implementing the Education 2030 agenda.

As the scope and content of the legal obligations under the right to education are aligned with the 10 targets of SDG 4, efforts are being made to ensure that the components of the targets are included in the guidelines and that these guidelines serve as a valuable contribution to monitoring progress towards SDG 4 targets.

Beyond SDG 4, the Convention is also closely aligned with the normative content on the right to education of other international human rights instruments such as the International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights (1966), Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of

Discrimination against Women (1979), the Convention on the Rights of the Child (1989) and the Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (2006).

In addition, this Consultation is an opportunity to inform the ongoing **UNESCO Initiative on the Evolving Right to Education within a lifelong learning perspective**¹ (launched in December 2021). The Initiative investigates how the right to education could be reinforced placing it within a lifelong learning perspective and in light of the new demands being placed on education. This Initiative builds on the **Report from the International Commission on the Futures of Education**², which suggests to broaden our understanding of the right to education to clearly apply it to all ages and across all times and spaces. The initiative is also in-line with the **Vision Statement of the United Nations Secretary General on Transforming Education**³, and the **Report on the 2022 Transforming Education Summit**⁴ which call for the transformation of education systems to 'include everyone, regardless of circumstance, context or background'. The Initiative on the Evolving Right to Education aims to open a collaborative and participatory discussion about the international framework to ensure the effective enforcement of the right to education and learning throughout life for all. Finally, the Initiative builds on recent inter-governmental dialogues, including the Marrakech Framework for Action for Adult Learning and Education⁵ and the Tashkent Declaration on Early Childhood Care and Education.⁶

It is also important to note that previous consultations on the Convention and Recommendation revealed that countries now understand the right to education in an extended manner. The 11th consultation builds on the findings of the previous national reports to include various areas that have direct repercussions on the right to education such as, for instance, digital learning, climate considerations, lifelong learning entitlement, and the role of non-state actors in education.

3. Reporting obligations

There are differences in the legal nature of the obligations under the Convention, as distinguished from those under the Recommendation. The Convention has binding force and the States Parties are under the obligation to incorporate its provisions into their domestic frameworks. The Recommendation, non-binding in nature, has political and moral force. Its adoption sought to take into account the difficulties that certain States might experience in ratifying the Convention, in particular with respect to their federal structure.

Bearing in mind the differences in legal scope inherent to the nature of these two categories of instruments, the content of the Recommendation is identical to that of the Convention. Member States are expected to give effect to it in national legislation and education policies.

The reporting obligation under the provisions of Article VII of the Convention and of the Recommendation is the same. Article VIII of UNESCO's Constitution states that "*Each Member State shall submit to the Organization, at such times and in such manner as shall be determined by the General Conference, reports on the laws, regulations and statistics relating to its educational, scientific and cultural institutions and activities, and on the action taken upon the recommendations and conventions referred to in Article IV, paragraph 4*". Therefore, even if a country is not a State Party to the Convention, it needs to submit a report on the implementation of the Recommendation, which means that **all UNESCO Member States are expected to submit a national report** on the implementation of these instruments in the context of monitoring consultations.

¹ <https://www.unesco.org/en/right-education/evolving>

² <https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000379707>

³ https://www.un.org/sites/un2.un.org/files/2022/09/sg_vision_statement_on_transforming_education.pdf

⁴ https://www.un.org/sites/un2.un.org/files/report_on_the_2022_transforming_education_summit.pdf

⁵ [Marrakech Framework for Action | Institute for Lifelong Learning \(unesco.org\)](https://www.unesco.org/en/marrakech-framework-for-action)

⁶ [Tashkent-declaration-ecce-2022.pdf \(unesco.org\)](https://www.unesco.org/en/tashkent-declaration-ecce-2022)

4. Participation in consultations

The reporting period for the 11th consultation on the implementation of the Convention and the Recommendation covers four years (2021-2024).

The Futures of Education Report calls for a new social contract for education, which requires to understand education as a common good and a shared societal endeavour. To ensure this, extensive consultations involving a broad range of stakeholders is needed. The reporting process therefore needs to be **participatory**. This includes ensuring cooperation between ministries of education and other ministries dealing with aspects of the right to education as well as consulting social partners and **civil society organizations** and other relevant bodies.

The preparation of national reports provides a **good opportunity** for Member States to assess the implementation of the right to education in their country, identify specific challenges, build constructive dialogue with other actors involved in this field and share good practices.

In the preparation of reports, Member States are encouraged to provide **substantive and relevant information in a concise manner**. In addition to a description of the constitutional, legislative, administrative, and policy framework established for the implementation of the provisions guaranteed by the instruments, the information supplied by Member States should demonstrate how legal norms and practices comply with the Convention and the Recommendation.

Relevant information supplied for other reporting instances may be reproduced or referred to with precise indication as to its retrieval. Similarly, hyperlinks to any useful documents or relevant legal and policy texts are most welcome and texts can also be added in the annex.

Country reports submitted for previous consultations can be found on the **Observatory on the right to education**⁷ in the monitoring section of the country profile. The information provided in the reports are valuable both for the Observatory on the right to education as well as for **HerAtlas**⁸, the online monitoring tool for girls' and women's right to education. Information and data regarding countries' education systems are also available through the UNESCO Institute for Statistics database⁹. Beyond monitoring purposes, the consultation findings and reports inform broader work - serving for knowledge generation, advocacy, and technical cooperation.

5. Modalities and structure

The Guidelines are structured around three chapters:

- The **first chapter** covers general information on adherence to the Convention.
- The **second chapter** aims to gather information on the implementation of the Convention and Recommendation in the context of Sustainable Development Goal 4. As the most extensive part of the Guidelines, this chapter covers: inclusion and non-discrimination in education (section 1), all levels and forms of education (section 2), quality education provision and learning environment (section 3) and finally, strengthening governance systems (section 4).
- The **third chapter** seeks to obtain information on the methods used to draw the attention of the various authorities in the country to the instruments.

With a view to simplify the Guidelines while providing necessary substantive information to assist Member States in the preparation of responses, through a participatory process, **two types of guidance** are provided:

⁷ <http://www.unesco.org/education/edurights/index.php?action=home&lng=en>

⁸ <https://en.unesco.org/education/girls-women-rights>

⁹ [UIS Statistics \(unesco.org\)](http://uis.unesco.org)

- (1) Open-ended and closed-ended questions to be directly filled in by Member States. Please note that multiple answers may be provided where relevant.
- (2) Additional information aimed at guiding Members States to structure and detail their responses to the open-ended questions (including remarks on how to respond efficiently to the questions raised). These elements are presented in italics.

GENERAL INFORMATION:

Country name: **REPUBLIC OF CYPRUS**

Organization or entity responsible for the preparation of the report: **MINISTRY OF EDUCATION, SPORT AND YOUTH**

Name of contact person: **Dr Ioannis SAVVIDES, Head of International and European Affairs Bureau**

Email and telephone number of contact person: **+357 22 800 697, isavvides@moe.gov.cy**

I. Ratification and applicability of the Convention against Discrimination in Education¹⁰

- Is your country a State Party to the Convention?

☒ **Yes**

☐ No: Does your country plan to ratify this instrument?

☐ Yes: Please indicate the stage of ratification process reached by your country and whether assistance is needed:

☐ There is interest but no concrete action has been taken

☐ The ratification process has been initiated

☐ The ratification process is close to completion

- Please briefly explain the steps that have been taken and timeline when relevant, any difficulties encountered (legal, institutional, political or practical) in completing the ratification process. And how UNESCO can assist:

☐ No, not considering ratification. Please explain why:

- Is the Convention directly applicable in your country's domestic law?

☒ **Yes** ☐ No

- Have courts, tribunals and/or administrative authorities adjudicated on issues or violations regarding the right to education?¹¹

☐ No

¹⁰

<https://www.unesco.org/en/legal-affairs/convention-against-discrimination-education>

¹¹

Judicial mechanisms play an important role in enforcing the right to education by ensuring legal accountability and therefore contributing to the practical realization of the right to education.

☐ Yes: Have the provisions of the Convention been invoked?

☐ Yes ☐ No

- Please cite the case law and jurisprudence.

Information could also be given about the judicial, administrative and other competent authorities having jurisdiction with respect to the right to education.

II. Information on the implementation of the Convention or Recommendation in the context of Sustainable Development Goal 4 (SDG4)

1. Towards an inclusive non-discriminatory education system

For reference: This section relates to the main purpose of the Convention/Recommendation that is to underscore the state obligation to proscribe any form of discrimination in education while promoting equality of educational opportunity as laid out in Articles/Paragraphs 1(1), 2 and 3 of the Convention/Recommendation.

It further corresponds to the overall aspiration of SDG4 which aims to “ensure inclusive and equitable quality education and promote lifelong learning opportunities for all” by 2030. While it covers all the SDG4 targets, it also specifically covers SDG target 4.5.¹²

- Please indicate whether the rights and principles laid out in the Convention/Recommendation informed the elaboration of the education legal and/or policy framework:

✓ Yes ☐ No

- If yes, please provide reference:

The rights and principles laid out in the Convention/Recommendation are in line with the general framework and policies undertaken by the Republic of Cyprus for inclusive education.

1.1 Non-discrimination and equality in education

- Please indicate measures adopted to both prevent and eliminate discrimination in education within the meaning of the Convention/Recommendation¹³, and ensure equal access to all levels and types of education (please tick all that apply):

For reference: This notably is covered under SDG target 4.1 and partly target 4.b¹⁴

¹² Which calls on states to “eliminate gender disparities in education and ensure equal access to all levels of education and vocational training for the vulnerable, including persons with disabilities, indigenous peoples and children in vulnerable situations”.

¹³ See: Article/Paragraph 1(1).

¹⁴ Which calls on states to “substantially expand globally the number of scholarships available [...] for enrolment in higher education, including vocational training and information and communications technology, technical, engineering and scientific programmes”.

✓ **Legal texts¹⁵ prohibit discrimination and guarantee equal access to education:**

- ✓ **In pre-primary education (including early learning and care)**
- ✓ **In primary education**
- ✓ **In secondary education**
- ✓ **In technical and vocational education and training**
- ✓ **In higher education**
- ✓ **In adult education and alternative learning**

- Please indicate the relevant legal provisions:

The right to education for all children is safeguarded by Article 20 of the Constitution of the Republic of Cyprus. Moreover, the equality of all children enrolled in schools is guaranteed by the legislation.

The regulations for the operation of public secondary schools clearly state that any person or public authority involved in the interpretation or implementation of the regulations is obliged to refrain from "any discrimination based on race, colour, gender, language, religion, political and other beliefs of the child or his/her parents or guardians, citizenship, ethnic or social origin, economic situation, disability, birth, sexual orientation or any other situation". Thus, any discriminatory attitudes based on religion or belief are strictly forbidden.

"Access to Higher Education for All" is set as one of the main goals in the Strategic Plan of the Department of Higher Education (DHE) of the Ministry of Education, Sports and Youth (MESY). To achieve this goal, several actions are in place, deriving from either the national laws/policies or the policies of the Higher Education Institutions (HEIs), as described in Section 1.2. below.

Under the National Law of the Conduct of the Pancyprian Examinations for Entry at the Public HEIs of Cyprus, all secondary education graduates are entitled to participate in the Pancyprian (National) Exams, without exclusion. At the same time, the Examination Service responsible for conducting the Pancyprian Examinations has set and follows certain procedures for providing special arrangements in Pancyprian Examinations for candidates with disabilities. Additionally, a number of candidates from vulnerable groups who pass the Pancyprian Examinations can be admitted to Public HEIs based on Special Criteria (including that of disadvantaged socio-economic background), provided that they satisfy the minimum entry requirements set in the relevant law. Legislation and procedures are in place to facilitate students with disabilities once entering and studying at HEIs.

The Students Welfare Law has the following objectives: (a) the provision of Student Sponsorships, i.e. financial support based on economic criteria (income and economic status) and (b) the provision of Student allowances, i.e. financial allowance for housing, books, food and computer purchasing based on socio-economic criteria and family background. The sponsorships and allowances are provided to students of ISCED levels 5, 6 and 7 that are permanent residents of Cyprus for studies in HEIs in Cyprus or abroad based on criteria and preconditions described in the Law.

The Cyprus Agency of Quality Assurance and Accreditation in Higher Education (CYQAA), competent authority for all matters of quality assurance adhering to the

¹⁵ Constitution, laws, decrees, regulations, circulars, etc.

principles of the UN resolutions and UNESCO recommendations for the rights of persons with disabilities, has established procedures and criteria in order to ascertain that HEIs in Cyprus cater to the needs of all students improving thus, the social dimension, equity, inclusion or diversity in Higher Education. This is done through the published standards applied for external quality assurance conducted by the Agency.

- Please list the prohibited grounds of discrimination in education as laid out in legal texts:

Any discrimination based on race, colour, gender, language, religion, political and other beliefs of the child or his/her parents or guardians, citizenship, ethnic or social origin, economic situation, disability, birth, sexual orientation or any other situation.

✓ **Policies, programmes and initiatives aim to prohibit and prevent discrimination and ensure equal access to education**

- ✓ **In pre-primary education (including early learning and care)**
- ✓ **In primary education**
- ✓ **In secondary education**
- ✓ **In technical and vocational education and training**
- ✓ **In higher education**
- ✓ **In adult education and alternative learning**

- Please provide details:

Programs and initiatives aimed to support and assist children of migrant biography or/and those coming from families with migrant background, refugees and Unaccompanied Minors / Applicants of International Protection

The Ministry of Education, Sport and Youth (MESY), in the framework of its educational policy, applies the basic principle of offering the same opportunities for access to education to all students without any discrimination or differentiation, thus contributing to the support of children of migrant biography or/and those coming from families with migrant background, refugees and Unaccompanied Minors / Applicants of International Protection.

In this context, and given the ongoing increasing and unpredictable migrant flows that have changed the composition of students' population, the Sector of Migrant Biography of the Department of General Secondary Education, in close collaboration with the Interdepartmental Committee for the Integration of Children of Migrant Background into the Cypriot Educational System, which comprises of representatives of all Departments of Education (Primary, General Secondary, General Technical and Vocational Education), The Cyprus Pedagogical Institute and the Centre of Educational Research and Evaluation, as well as according to the suggestions of the experts of the European Commission who visited Cyprus in March 2019, has designed several educational programmes for students of Migrant Background that address as many of their needs as possible regarding both learning objectives and personal issues.

Currently, the Ministry offers five different Programs for the teaching of Greek as a second language in secondary schools and in State Institutes for Further Education. Namely, “The intensive program in transitional classes (offered in High schools)”, “The program for the teaching of Greek as a second language (offered in specific High schools with a small number of students with Migrant background)”, “The Educational Program for Unaccompanied Minors / Applicants of International Protection (offered in lyceums and technical schools)”, “The programme for the intensive teaching of Greek as a second language offered in lyceums” and “The program offered at the State Institutes for Further Education for Unaccompanied Minors / Applicants of International Protection”. For instance, the Educational Programme for Unaccompanied Minors / Applicants of International Protection (in operation both in lyceums and in technical schools) offers an intensive course of Greek as a Second Language.

During the school year 2023-24, the programs operate in 9 schools (5 lyceums and 4 technical schools) in Nicosia, Limassol and Larnaca, during the normal school hours/timetable (morning sessions, from 7.30 a.m. until 13.35 p.m.). In this program, as operated in lyceums, Greek with elements of History and Culture is taught 20 periods per week, while students also take lessons in Mathematics (2 periods), English (4 periods), Computers (2 periods), Design and Technology (3 periods), Arts (2 periods), Physical Education (4 periods).

Due to the ongoing increase of the number of Unaccompanied Minors / Applicants of International Protection and according to the relevant Ministers’ Decision (no. 87.593), an afternoon Educational Program, offering lessons in Greek as a Second Language and Mathematics is in operation at State Institutes of Training. This program is offered to students who could not be hosted in the morning programs due to shortage of places in schools (lyceums or technical schools). During the current school year (2023-2024), the Program is offered in Nicosia (Institutes of Acropolis and Kykkos), Larnaca (Institute of Livadia) and Paphos (Institute at Lyceum of Archbishop Makarios the 3rd).

For the operation of the above Programs, the Ministry, as well as the schools that host such programs – stand in close collaboration with the Services of Social Welfare and other partners, in order to resolve any problems that emerge during the school year.

Furthermore, and in line with the Ministry’s applied policies of supporting children of migrant biography as well as according to the basic principle of fighting stereotyping and discrimination against persons based on different national descent, religion or beliefs, the Sector of Migrant Biography further organises several extracurricular activities in collaboration with Secondary Schools and other partners’ / key stakeholders. All these activities are closely related to the primary aim of developing active and democratic citizens who are deeply aware of social challenges and sensitive towards any form of stigmatization and violence. The outer purpose of these actions is to promote social inclusion and work towards the creation of a better society that is open and welcoming for all its members, regardless their background or personal beliefs. The following activities are not a part of the students’ formal curriculum and students’ participation in them is optional. However, schools are encouraged to promote their students’ participation through regular bulletins and supportive correspondence communicated to them by the Sector.

1) Annual Competition “Ξένιος Ζευς” (Xenios Zeus)

Taking its name by Zeus, the ancient Greek god of hospitality, this annual competition (now in its third year) aims to encourage students to think about social inclusion,

acceptance and the importance of co-operation. The competition is announced in December every year and results are examined by specialised committees and announced about three months later. Students are usually prompted to work on a project either personally or as a part of a team under the guidance and supervision of one of their teachers and submit their work in about one or two months after the competition call. Students are expected to work on this competition in their free time and create original work on several fields, such as the creating of a song, painting, story or polytropic text. The competition bears a distinctive title every year, usually inspired by famous sayings regarding the importance of freedom, respect and acceptance. The competition is especially addressed to schools where Courses of Greek as a Second Language are in operation, but it is at the same time open to all students of Secondary Education that would like to reflect on the phenomena of racism and migration in society. To encourage as much participation as possible, the best creations and practices are presented in a special ceremony, where students who have submitted the best projects receive awards and prizes.

2) Intercultural Activities Month

As of school year 2023-2024, the Sector of Migrant Biography launched a new series of activities under the general title “We are all the same. We are all different”. In this context, the Sector determined a certain period between January and February during which schools were encouraged to organise certain activities beyond formal classes in which students would reflect upon aspects of intercultural relations and social inclusions. More specifically, under each school’s individual guidelines, students were prompted to collect myths and stories from different countries and organise sessions of storytelling, present literary works from different countries in various mother tongues in the framework of the school’s Reading Club, create records of traditional recipes, traditions and songs as these are kept by the families, both of Cypriot and migrant descent. The outer aim of this long series of activities was to offer the students’ the opportunity to get in touch with several other cultures, understand similarities among people as well as have the opportunity to present aspects of their own culture and thus get their voice heard. Schools were requested to send a short report of the activities that were implemented by their students. A selection of activities by various schools is aimed to be presented at the Intercultural Festival.

3) Intercultural Festival

Following the Competition and the Month of Intercultural Activities at schools, the Sector of Migrant Biography is planning the organisation of a big-scale Pancyprian Festival devoted to the promotion of intercultural relations, co-operation, social inclusion and anti-racism. The Festival will comprise of two sessions: the Ceremony of award giving to all students that earned awards and prizes at the Annual Competition “Ξένιος Ζεϋς” (Xenios Zeus) and the presentation of a selection of activities that the schools hosted during the Intercultural Month. The aim of this event is to give the opportunity for more students coming from various ethnic backgrounds from all around Cyprus to gather together, learn from each other and present aspects of their traditions and cultures. At the same time, through the recognition of the most interesting and original works that schools have produced towards the aim of social inclusion and interculturalism, the Sector aims to offer a precious opportunity to showcase good practices of promoting collaboration and students’ inclusion. This is going to be a one-day event; small groups of students from all secondary schools in Cyprus are eligible to attend. In addition, representatives of

departments that collaborate closely with the Sector (e.g. Services of Social Welfare) will be invited to attend.

Further to the above, the Ministry of Education, Sport and Youth offers a variety of educational activities / seminars in order to assist students, educators and overall staff in embracing diversity and social inclusion. In addition, through school networking and professional “teacher observing teacher” programs, further professional development is sought.

The Career Counselling and Educational Services (CCES) which operates under the administration of the Secondary General Education of the MESY, focuses on the personal, interpersonal, educational and career development of high school students (Secondary General Education and Secondary Technical and Vocational Education and Training Schools) and other young people. Through the counselling process and the career guidance, school counsellors help students to:

- adjust to the school environment, set goals and grow personally and academically,
- develop positive self-esteem and acquire the skills to deal effectively with personal, family and/or interpersonal issues,
- grow and accept themselves and others,
- learn and acquire decision making skills and techniques in order to make well informed decisions concerning educational, career and personal choices,
- identify their individual capabilities, interests and skills – reach self-awareness,
- explore different types of careers and gain valuable knowledge about the modern socio-economic and cultural developments.

School counsellors offer individual and group counselling and may facilitate other programs such as the School Mediation Program that is a peaceful conflict resolution program which empowers teachers and students to promote fairness and respect in the school community.

Additionally, school counsellors provide training to students and students trained in peaceful conflict resolution skills, can support their peers in conflict to reach peaceful agreements through a mediation process.

Furthermore, school counsellors, like all members of school units, follow and implement the MESY’s Antiracist Policy.

All of the above services are offered based on the uniqueness of each person and thus play a significant role in fostering an inclusive environment where diversity is embraced.

The Department of Secondary Technical and Vocational Education and Training of the MESY offers a wide range of technical and vocational education, initial training, lifelong training programmes and higher vocational education and training to all eligible gymnasium leavers and adults through the following pathways:

- Secondary Technical and Vocational Education (morning classes)
- Apprenticeship System of Vocational Education and Training
- Post-Secondary Institutes of Vocational Education and Training (Public School of Higher VET)

- Evening Schools of Technical and Vocational Education (second chance schools)
- Lifelong Learning Programmes of Vocational Education and Training (Afternoon and Evening Classes non-formal education).

The vision of the Department is to ensure an attractive, flexible and high quality Technical and Vocational Education and Training System that is equally accessible to all and can respond to the needs of the economy and society of Cyprus.

The Department of Higher Education (DHE) systematically collects and analyses data on a longitudinal basis regarding a wide spectrum of variables related to various aspects of Higher Education (such as the synthesis of student population, access and completion, the synthesis of teaching/academic staff, programs of study offered, participation in European University Alliances). In terms of disabilities, the DHE collects data on the type of disability HE students have or on the type of difficulty they face. The DHE provides nine options for the categorization of disabilities/difficulties. The data is collected twice per academic year through Higher Education Institutions' (HEI) registries. The ultimate purpose is to provide to DHE the evidence base for both decision and policy making in order to enhance Higher Education in Cyprus.

At an institutional level, several HEIs have set policies to ensure equality of opportunities. Student support is provided covering the needs of a diverse student population, such as mature, part-time students, students in employment, international students and students with special needs. All HEIs in Cyprus have a Student Welfare Unit which is responsible to address issues related to social dimension. At the same time, some HEIs have established offices dealing with ensuring equality of opportunities. For example, the University of Cyprus has established the Office for Diversity, Equality and Inclusivity which aims to create a fair, safe and pleasant environment, where all students and staff members, within and beyond their multiple identities, will be supported, both in their professional and personal development.

Finally, the Cyprus Lifelong Learning Strategy (CyLLLS) for the years 2021-2027 is envisioned to provide the long-term strategic framework towards the development of a knowledge-based society, where all citizens are provided with learning opportunities, to develop the knowledge, skills, and attitudes that will facilitate their personal and social growth, professional advancement, social inclusion, resilience, and well-being. In this context, Inclusion and equality is one of its six strategic horizontal pillars and aspires to provide accessible and available lifelong learning opportunities to all citizens so they can develop their skills, participate in society, and succeed in life. Equal treatment and opportunities for lifelong learning are to be provided regardless of social class, gender, ethnicity, religion, disability, age, and sexual orientation. Issues, such as equal and inclusive attainment in early childhood education, provision of alternative pathways to dropouts, upskilling and reskilling of low qualified adults, accessible educational opportunities for persons with disabilities, pathways for re-entering education, or an efficient VET system are of particular importance for the CyLLLS. The CyLLLS 2021-2027 is coordinated by the Ministry of Education, Sport and Youth (MESY) and its work is facilitated by two committees, the National and Technical Committees for lifelong learning which are responsible for the development, supervision, monitoring, and updating of the strategy.

Human Resource Development Authority, the Directorate General Growth of the Ministry of Finance, the Youth Board of Cyprus, the Foundation of the Management

of Lifelong Learning Programmes are some of the Members of the two Committees. The programmes that are provided by the various departments of the MESY aim to increase participation of adults in lifelong learning, in both the formal and the non-formal sector. Specifically, the departments offer a wide range of education and training opportunities, either free of charge (e.g. evening schools) or at a very low cost, with the aim of fostering personal development and fulfilment or enhancing participants' skills and competences. Additionally, fees are waived for certain social groups, such as pensioners and adults in rural areas, as is the case with Adult Education Centres. Finally, tuition fees are reduced or fully exempted for specific vulnerable groups to ensure broader access to adult education and training.

✓ **Combatting discrimination in terms of curriculum:**

- ✓ **In pre-primary education (including early learning and care)**
- ✓ **In primary education**
- ✓ **In secondary education**
- ✓ **In technical and vocational education and training**
- ✓ **In higher education**
- ☐ **In adult education and alternative learning**

- Please provide details:

The creation of a sensitization culture against racism, intolerance, negative stereotyping and the promotion of equality and respect of human rights, is an integral part and the underlying philosophy, of the curricula of various subjects.

More specifically, the Ministry of Education, Sport and Youth (MESY) implements human rights, anti-racist and intercultural education through the Health Education Curriculum that includes clearly defined success indicators related to issues concerning human rights education. More particularly, it includes indicators associated with intimidating behaviour, violence, social identities/gender development, respect for diversity, taking action for peaceful coexistence.

The content of Health Education Subject is analysed in four fields, each one consists of different modules. Two of the four fields emphasize the creation and improvement of social self and creating an active citizen. Pupils taking the Health Education subject (obligatory in Gymnasium, optional in Lyceum) have the opportunity not only to develop communication skills but also to emphasize in understanding the right to live in a multicultural society and to respect other people's boundaries.

Religious education in public schools is not taught in the form of indoctrination. Pupils learn about the Christian Orthodox beliefs (the predominant faith). Moreover, they are introduced to the basic aspects of other religions and develop a critical attitude towards them, so as to become able to understand and respect the religious beliefs of others. Therefore, the religious education provided in Cyprus is consistent with the religious sentiment of the majority of citizens and fully respects the principles of religious freedom, equality and human dignity. Non-Christian/Orthodox pupils can be exempted from the subject. At the same time schools facilitate children of other religions in their faith practices.

The Department of Higher Education (DHE) of the MESY is not involved in the design of the curricula of the programmes of study offered by the Higher Education Institution's (HEI). Although, a recent mapping of the courses on human rights offered and the available personnel with expertise in human rights education undertaken by the DHE, showed that the HEIs offer specific courses/programmes for human rights. Also, they have personnel with expertise in related subjects.

✓ **Other measures adopted to both prevent and eliminate discrimination in education and ensure equal access to all levels and types of education:**

Equal access to education and elimination of discrimination is one of the main goals set by the Ministry of Education, Sport and Youth (MESY).

1) Pupils/ students with disabilities

According to the Special Education Legislation, the District Committees for Special Education decide on provisions and / or any other accommodations in order to assist children with special needs who attend public schools.

Children with special needs, who attend mainstream class in public schools, attend supportive teaching classes based on the curriculum. The curriculum is adjusted to their individual learning needs.

In Secondary Education, support is provided by teachers of the mainstream class. Additionally, pupils with special needs receive modifications, such as extra completion time, exemption from spelling mistakes, and so on.

Furthermore, children who attend Special Units are enrolled on the school's registry. Pupils, who attend Special Units in Primary and Secondary Education, participate in activities and lessons of the mainstream class, based on their capabilities and individual needs. Pupils, who attend the Lyceum Special Units, have a three-day class programme in their school unit and a two-day pre-vocational training programme at selected workplaces. A special programme on Hotel and Catering runs in Secondary Technical and Vocational Education and Training. In Secondary Education, pupils who attend Special Units receive a "Certificate of Attendance".

2) Pupils/ students from poor households

The Ministry provides breakfast during the school year to public school pupils from all levels of education who need help, as well as to the pupils participating in the New Modern Apprenticeship Programme.

The aim of this Programme is to secure that children from disadvantaged families are provided with a nutritious breakfast, minimizing the possibility of malnutrition and preventing low school performance, social exclusion and the risk of early school leaving.

The children eligible to participate in the programme are selected based on financial and social criteria, such as the following: - families who receive the Guaranteed Minimum Income, - unemployed parents, - orphans, - single parent families, - multi-child families (families over three children), and - families with an especially inadequate income due to other reasons.

The Ministry acknowledges the necessity of introduction and use of ICT in Education. Thus, showing particular sensitivity in supporting needy students, the MESY grants the amount of €400 for the purchase of a laptop for students attending the 2nd grade of public Gymnasiums and private Secondary Schools (approved by the Ministry), and students attending the Preparatory class of the Evening Gymnasiums-Lyceums, whose families according to which receive a Municipal Law on Public Aid and Services or the Minimum Guaranteed Income or they themselves receive a Minimum Guaranteed Income or Public Aid in accordance with the Law on Public Aid and Services.

3) Pupils belonging to national minorities/religious groups according to the Cyprus Constitution

For the Republic of Cyprus the term “national minorities” designates only those minority-groups which had a traditional presence on the island at the time of the establishment of the Republic of Cyprus in 1960 and hold the Cypriot citizenship. Thus, “religious groups”, as defined in article 2(3) of the Constitution, are treated as national minorities.

The MESY that has an earmarked budget specifically for the support of the educational needs of the three religious groups. There is a different degree of autonomy in educational issues and each religious group has its own schools based on their needs and goals.

The educational needs of the Armenians are mainly supported through the operation of the Armenian Nareg Schools that are fully subsidized by the MESY. Armenian Nareg Schools are public schools that follow a differentiated program since the Armenian language, history, geography and religion are taught. The Armenian Nareg schools promote the Armenian identity in extra-curricular activities, such as, the offering of Armenian dance and music lessons. It must be noted that MESY also subsidizes the tuition fees of Armenian children that choose to be enrolled in private schools. Furthermore, the MESY has as a different budget for the operation of the Armenian School Board.

The educational needs of the Maronites are supported in “Agios Maronas” Pre-Primary and Primary School and are fully subsidized by the MESY. “Agios Maronas” Pre-Primary and Primary School, is a public school with a high attendance of pupils that belong to the Maronite religious group. The school follows the existing curriculum of public schools that includes specific attainment and adequacy indicators in all subjects. At the same time, the curriculum in History, Religious Education and Geography is enriched with content of specific interest to Maronites to cover aspects of the Maronite catholic religion, the history and culture of the Maronite community, for grades 1-6. Based on the enriched curriculum new teaching material was developed that covers aspects of the Maronite catholic religion, history, geography, and culture. The MESY has as a different budget for the operation of the Maronite School Board and subsidizes the transportation of Maronite children to the school.

4) Turkish Cypriot/Roma pupils

The department of Secondary Education is implementing various measures to ensure access to education for Roma students. More specifically, the following are implemented in a secondary school where a number of Roma pupils is enrolled:

- Employment of a Turkish Cypriot teacher who taught Turkish language 6 periods per week, History, Muslim religion and other social issues.
- Employment of a bilingual teacher in order to overcome the linguistic barrier arising from the low proficiency in the Greek language. Turkish Cypriot/Roma children attended Greek language lessons 6 periods per week. It is important to stress that Greek was taught as a second language and following the different level of attainment in Greek (Ellinomatheia) a differentiated instruction was employed during the lessons. The teacher also helped students improve academic achievement in other lessons of the curriculum.
- Special support teaching, through the European co-funded programme "School and Social Inclusion Actions+", with the provision for an assistant class teacher, promoting the learning process.
- Active participation of Turkish Cypriot/Roma pupils in various school events (anti-racist events, school conferences, extra curriculum activities).
- Cooking, graffiti, athletic events and other activities, both in morning and afternoon hours, in the framework of the implementation of the programme "School and Social Inclusion Actions".

- Regular Visits to the mosque of the region.
- Provision of access to a computer/ a tablet and internet at home, where storages in personal equipment and internet at home is reported.
- Provision of teaching Greek as a second language, free of charge, in state institute for further education to Parents and Guardians of Roma Children, in order to encourage participation of Cyprus Roma parents and guardians to education.
- Provision of homeschool program to Turkish-Cypriot/ Roma students at a high risk for school failure.
- Participation in the National Platform for Roma, coordinated by the Deputy Ministry of Social Welfare.
- Provision of breakfast to all Turkish Cypriot/Roma pupils students.
- Provision of special support to Roma students from the Service of Educational Psychology and the Social Welfare Services.
- In September 2022, pupils produced a short video in Turkish, describing, what they aspire for 2045. The video was produced following an initiative of the President of the 76th session of the General Assembly of the United Nations, with the name "Voices of Youth - Time Capsule". The collection of recordings after an initial period of screening will be sealed in physical and virtual formats and would be unveiled on the 100th anniversary of the founding of the United Nations.

5) Pupils with Migrant Background

As stated above, the MESY has developed and implemented an upgraded educational policy aiming at the smooth integration of pupils with migrant background into the educational system of Cyprus. A policy document was approved by the Minister and the departments have developed an action plan with a variety of targeted actions, through the prism of an intercultural approach, anti-racist education and the methodology of teaching Greek as a second language.

More specifically, the policy focuses on five priority areas: (1) learning the Greek language; (2) reception of newly arrived children with migrant background; (3) education and teachers' in-service training; (4) data collection and analysis of the needs of pupils with migrant background; (5) intercultural approach in the new curricula.

1.2 Equality of opportunities and inclusion in education

- Please indicate the actions taken/planned to ensure equality of opportunities (in terms of access, participation and completion), equal treatment and to support the inclusion of all learners in learning processes (*several items may be ticked*):

General measures:

- | | |
|--|--|
| √ Legislation provides for inclusive education for all | √ Multiple and flexible learning pathways ¹⁷ are provided for |
|--|--|

¹⁷ Multiple and flexible learning pathways are 'entry points and re-entry points at all ages and all educational levels, strengthened links between formal and non-formal structures, and recognition, validation and accreditation of the knowledge, skills and competencies acquired through nonformal and informal education' ([Education 2030 Framework for Action](#), para. 33). This may include student transfers between courses and institutions and diverse learning modalities (online, in-person, full-time, part-time, etc.) to respond to individual needs and interests.

- ✓ **Policy measures aim to enhance inclusion in education for all**
- ✓ **Teachers are trained on inclusive education¹⁶ and to value diversity**
- ✓ **Initiatives to address discrimination and promote cultural diversity and mutual acceptance**
- ☐ Other:
- ✓ **Curricula and teaching methods are inclusive in design¹⁸**
- ✓ **Multilingual and intercultural education is supported**

- Please elaborate and, where appropriate, indicate the legal and policy measures taken:

Regulations for primary and secondary education include the provision for inclusive education for all.

The antiracist policy of the Ministry of Education, Sports and Youth (MESY) «Code of Conduct against Racism & Guide for Managing and Recording Racist Incidents» is being implemented with the support of the Cyprus Pedagogical Institute (CPI) since the school year 2014-2015. The antiracist policy was developed based on the Follow-up Report of Cyprus for Recommendation No 20 and a recommendation by the Anti-Discrimination Body. The development and implementation of the policy responds to the European Commission's against Racism and Intolerance guideline No. 10 and is also in line with various international and European conventions that Cyprus has ratified, such as the Convention on the Rights of the Child, the Council of Europe's Recommendation CM/Rec (2010) of the Committee of Ministers to member states, the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Violence Against Women, and the European Social Charter.

Homophobia and transphobia are specifically categorized amongst the types of racist incidents that may be identified, managed and recorded by schools, based on the antiracist policy. The policy conceptualizes racism in a broad manner, including all sorts of discrimination. It includes definitions of basic concepts which form the theoretical background (e.g. racism, racist incident, discrimination, stereotypes, diversity, etc.), outlines the responsibilities and commitments, expected by each member of the school community, and provides the steps to be followed by schools for dealing with racist incidents in a practical rubric. It provides schools and teachers with a detailed plan on how to deal with and prevent racist incidents. As the antiracist views diversity as a multidimensional phenomenon, involving various aspects of people's identities, it is expected to contribute to the decrease of bullying and discrimination based on any form of diversity in schools, including religion, beliefs, ethnicity, language, appearance, disability, gender, sexual orientation, etc.

Since 2018, the CPI continues to organize and facilitate a "School Network for the Support of Antiracist Policy Implementation", which supports teachers from schools of all levels wishing to participate in the network while their school implements the MESY antiracist policy. Each school year, the network consists of around 30 schools of all levels. Several face to face and online meetings are conducted each year, aiming to empower and train these teachers in relation to the theoretical and practical aspects of the antiracist policy. Specifically, in relation to the conceptualization of racism in a broad manner, including all sorts of discrimination on a local and global level, the definitions of basic concepts which form the theoretical

¹⁶ Teachers are prepared to teach all student (beyond just students with disabilities), equipping them with knowledge, values and attitudes that permit every student to succeed. See: [UNESCO policy paper](#): Inclusive teaching: preparing all teachers to teach all students, 2020, p.14.

¹⁸ In designing the curricula and teaching methods, care is given to ensure that all students are provided with an inclusive and supportive learning experience that offers them the opportunity to succeed whatever their background.

background (e.g. racism, homophobia, transphobia, sexism, antigypsyism, racist incident, discrimination, stereotypes, diversity, etc.), the responsibilities and commitments, expected by each member of the school community, and the steps to be followed by schools for dealing with racist incidents. The theoretical concept of intersectionality permeates all trainings conducted, as the antiracist policy views diversity as a multidimensional phenomenon, involving various aspects of people's identities and contributes to the decrease of discrimination based on any form of diversity in schools, including religion, beliefs, ethnicity, language, appearance, disability, gender, sexual orientation, etc. In addition to the trainings, every year, the CPI offers support to the Network schools in the following ways:

- Continuous update of website (presentations, FAQs, supportive material etc)
- Support helpline (phone and email)
- Parents information leaflet about the policy in 7 languages (Greek, English, Arabic, Turkish, Russian, Romanian, Bulgarian)
- Focused training opportunities (school-based seminars, optional afternoon seminars, network meetings, conferences in collaboration with relevant NGOs and Bodies, e.g. UNHCR, Commissioner for Children's Rights etc).

Furthermore, the MESY supports participation in various European Projects and collaboration with other organizations on issues related to Human Rights in Education.

- **Participation in European Projects**

- ***Project "Geia Xara"***

The MESY and the CPI promote participation of students in the project titled "Geia Xara" (<https://www.geiaxara.eu/en/>). The project is co-funded by Asylum, Immigration and Integration Fund and Cyprus government (in cooperation with CARDET and Innovade) and its objective is to Greek language lessons for non-EU country minors as part of the measures to integrate asylum-seeking, refugee and women and girls from migrant background into the education system.

- ***Project BODI***

The CPI also participated in the European project BODI. The project aimed to contribute to the development of the following:

- 1) Development of education policies and practices on intercultural education, gender education and inclusion of children / parents of minority cultural backgrounds – through our analysis of existing practices and the assessment of the method we develop;
- 2) Development of teachers' competences through new methods for teacher training and new practical tools ready to adapt, concretely: (a) Develop an understanding of cultural differences having an impact on early childhood education, develop tools to solve possible tensions and conflicts; (b) Develop skills and creative tools to address issues of cultural diversity, gender, and health with the children; (c) Offer tools to involve parents (of migrant and non-migrant origin) and engage them in dialogue about sensitive issues such as cultural differences, gender, body, health
- 3) Development of school's capacity to address cultural diversity, to ensure that children of different cultural backgrounds and their parents are not excluded and equip children for participation in an intercultural society tolerant towards gender diversity. Offer tools and strategies to address sensitive issues such as gender.

- ***European transnational project SAFER - Training workshop/experiential workshop for the prevention of gender and all forms of violence in schools***

The CPI and the Department of Primary Education co-organized a training workshop/experiential workshop in collaboration with the European transnational project SAFER (Systematic Approaches for Equality of Gender), funded by the European Commission under the Rights, Equality and Citizenship (REC) program (Nicosia 17 and 21/9/19 and Limassol 24 and 28/9/19). The purpose of the training was to present practices for the prevention of gender and all forms of violence in schools, as well as to inform teachers of their own contribution to the prevention and management of such phenomena. The training focused on the following topics: (a) Gender stereotypes and violence, (b) Character Education, (c) Resilience, and (d) Life Skills. At the end of the training, the participants were expected to be able to implement a variety of classroom techniques and activities to eliminate attitudes and behaviors that stem from gender stereotypes and may turn into incidents of gender-based violence. An important part of the curriculum material focused on techniques derived from the field of Positive Psychology.

➤ ***Workshop on piloting the Council of Europe's Descriptors of Competences for Democratic Culture***

The CPI, under the guidelines of the Council of Europe (CoE), conducted one of the European workshops on piloting the Council of Europe's Descriptors of Competences for Democratic Culture (CDC) on 13th February 2017. The training was conducted based on and adapted for the needs of the Cypriot context, from a training guide provided by the CoE, which gives advice to education professionals on how to organize training for the piloting of the descriptors in the CDC framework. The Council of Europe has been actively promoting human rights and citizenship education for many years, providing comprehensive training programmes, manuals and educational materials both in schools and universities and through youth work and non-formal education. The methods are active and participative. The CDC model is based on four main categories of competence: values; knowledge and critical understanding; attitudes; and skills. Random examples would be valuing other human beings, human dignity and human rights; civic-mindedness; analytical and critical thinking skills; and knowledge and critical understanding of politics, law and human rights.

➤ ***Erasmus+ Program, EACEA 33/2014 - Key action 3: Support for policy reform - Initiatives for policy innovation "An innovative toolkit for inclusive decision making policies - iDecide"***

The Erasmus+ Program, EACEA 33/2014 - Key action 3: Support for policy reform - Initiatives for policy innovation "An innovative toolkit for inclusive decision making policies - iDecide" (2017-2018, <https://www.idecide-project.eu/>) aimed to support policy makers, school principals and teachers in developing inclusive policies and practices in schools. In the application developed in the context of this project, special references are made to people with disabilities or belonging to minorities (e.g. people with mobility, visual, auditory or other disabilities, people with learning or other difficulties, etc.).

• **Collaboration with other organizations on issues of Human Rights Education**

In terms of antisemitism, the MESY organizes educational visits in collaboration with the Vad Yashem International School of Holocaust Studies for teachers and students once a year. For the purposes of the programme, the MESY also organizes in Cyprus a special conference for teachers on the pedagogical practices of the Holocaust and a specialized educator gives in-service seminars on the subject both for students and teachers.

The CPI, in collaboration with the UNHCR Cyprus Office, organised two conference on issues of migration and asylum in education: a) on 25th November 2017, at the University of Nicosia, titled "People on the move: pedagogical tools for cultivating empathy for refugee and migrant children", and b) on 3rd November 2018, at the CPI, in Nicosia, titled "Refugees and Migrants: Pedagogical Approaches".

Since 2017, the CPI and MESY have been supporting, under the guidelines of the Bicomunal Technical Committee of Education, the IMAGINE programme, in collaboration with the Association for Historical Dialogue and Research at the "Home for Cooperation". The programme includes experiential activities related to human rights and anti-racism within the education for a culture of peace. It is under the auspices of the Technical Committee on Education and has been approved by the negotiators of the two communities. Following the successful completion of the activities of the Imagine Education Programme (2017-2019) and the participation of approximately 5000 pupils and 600 teachers from all the communities in Cyprus, the programme team has announced its continuation for the school year 2019-2020 and has enriched it with more activities and meetings between children. During the programme, pupils engage in pedagogical activities in which Greek-Cypriot pupils will come into contact with Turkish-Cypriot pupils of the same age, accompanied by their teachers. Activities are held in the UN controlled area of Ledra Palace during school time. The programme pillars include an anti-racist workshop in schools and contact preparation (before the meeting with pupils from the Turkish Cypriot/Greek Cypriot community). Imagine trainers visit classrooms and engage children in experiential activities discussing issues of stereotyping, discrimination and racism as components of the culture of violence and preparing the conditions for a bi-communal meeting in the "Home for Cooperation". Then the pupils participate in bi-communal activities that take place in three languages (Greek, Turkish, English), with the option of repetition.

In the context of the operation of the Apprenticeship System, the Department of Secondary Technical and Vocational Education and Training of the MESY offers the level of the Preparatory Apprenticeship. Preparatory Apprenticeship operates as a safety net, addressing pupils who have dropped out of formal education programmes before completing their compulsory education (lower secondary education). Pupils enrolled at this level are usually between the ages of fifteen and sixteen. In exceptional cases, and with the permission of the Minister of Education, Sport and Youth, pupils aged below fifteen, but at least fourteen, may enrol. Preparatory Apprenticeship does not involve any work-based learning or in-company training or working for an employer. It offers one year or two-year entirely school-based programmes of study, aiming to help pupils develop their interpersonal and social skills, as well as strengthen their literacy, numeracy and ICT skills, through using a variety of pedagogical approaches not usually implemented in the formal school system. Furthermore, pupils of the Preparatory Apprenticeship have the opportunity to explore their talents and abilities through creative arts, and to take part in workshops related to technical occupations, such as carpentry, plumbing and mechanics. Pupils also receive individual counselling from psychologists, according to their needs. Pupils who complete Preparatory Apprenticeship (EQF level 2) may proceed to the Core Apprenticeship level (EQF level 3) or, if they wish, and provided they succeed in a special set of exams, they may re-enter the formal education system.

Another policy implemented by the Department of Secondary Technical and Vocational Education and Training aiming to provide programmes of study in order to enhance inclusion in education for all, is the operation of the Evening Schools of Technical and Vocational Education. These schools are second chance schools, offering formal upper Secondary Technical and Vocational Education to adult learners of all ages who are early school leavers, provided that they have completed their compulsory education (lower secondary education). Attendance is free of charge. The programmes offered at the five (5) Evening Schools of Technical and Vocational Education are equivalent to the formal Secondary Technical and Vocational Education programmes that are offered in the morning, adapted however to the particular characteristics and needs of adult learners. Thus, early school leavers have the opportunity to re-enter the formal education system and obtain a qualification at upper secondary level (School Leaving Certificate at EQF level 4) which allows them to pursue

studies at higher education level if they wish and/or re-enter the labour market directly as skilled workers.

It is worth mentioning that the programmes offered in the context of the Core Apprenticeship level have been linked to the formal programmes offered by the Evening Schools of Technical and Vocational Education, which, as mentioned above, operate as second chance schools for adult learners. Graduates of the Apprenticeship System are entitled to attend the Evening Schools of Technical and Vocational Education with part of their education and training being recognised and transferred. As a result, they are given the opportunity to complete upper Secondary TVET in two years instead of three. In this way, the Apprenticeship System has stopped being a dead-end, facilitating Apprenticeship graduates to pursue further studies.

“Access to Higher Education for All” is one of the main goals set out in the Strategic Plan of the Department of Higher Education (DHE) of the MESY. To achieve this goal, several actions are in place, deriving from either the national laws/policies or the policies of the Higher Education Institutions (HEI) in Cyprus.

Specifically, under the National Law of the Conduct of the Pancyprian Examinations for Entry to the Public HEIs of Cyprus, all secondary education graduates are entitled to participate in the Pancyprian (National) Exams, without exclusion. At the same time, the Examination Service responsible for conducting the Pancyprian Examinations has set and follows certain procedures for providing special arrangements in Pancyprian Examinations for candidates with disabilities.

During 2022, the Examinations Service, in collaboration with the University of Cyprus, organised Special Pancyprian Exams, with differentiated examination tests from those of the Pancyprian (National) Exams, which were adapted to the needs of a specific candidate for whom special arrangements were not enough to participate equally in the Pancyprian (National) Exams 2022. For the purposes of administering Special Pancyprian Examinations, the Undergraduate Rules of the University of Cyprus were first amended, with the addition of a specific reference to the organisation of such Special Examinations by the Ministry of Education in cooperation with the University of Cyprus.

Additionally, a number of candidates from vulnerable groups who pass the Pancyprian Examinations can be admitted to Public HEIs based on special criteria (including that of disadvantaged socio-economic background), provided that they satisfy the minimum entry requirements set in the relevant law.

Financial support is also provided to students (especially those from disadvantaged backgrounds), in several ways. Indicatively, a 'student grant' can be awarded to undergraduate and graduate students studying at accredited programmes of study to support their studies in Cyprus and/or abroad. The 'student allowance' is a targeted need-based grant to cover living expenses, books, rental and computer expenses of undergraduate and graduate students. Student grants and allowances target students from the following groups: special education needs, disabilities, refugee status, low socio-economic status, family background (e.g. single parent, from care homes). The grant provider is the Student Welfare Service, established under the Ministry of Finance, which is responsible for both the 'student grant' and the 'student allowance'.

The DHE systematically collects and analyses data on a longitudinal basis regarding a wide spectrum of variables related to various aspects of Higher Education (such as the synthesis of student population, access and completion, the synthesis of teaching/academic staff, programs of study offered, participation in European University Alliances). In terms of disabilities, the DHE collects data on the type of disability HE students have or on the type of difficulty they face. The DHE provides nine options for the categorization of disabilities/difficulties. The data is collected twice per academic year through HEIs' registries.

The ultimate purpose is to provide to DHE the evidence base for both decision and policy making in order to enhance Higher Education in Cyprus.

At an institutional level, several HEIs have set policies to ensure equality of opportunities. Student support is provided covering the needs of a diverse student population, such as mature, part-time students, students in employment, international students and students with special needs. All HEIs in Cyprus have a Student Welfare Unit which is responsible to address issues related to social dimension. At the same time, some HEIs have established offices dealing with ensuring equality of opportunities. For example, the University of Cyprus has established the Office for Diversity, Equality and Inclusivity which aims to create a fair, safe and pleasant environment, where all students and staff members, within and beyond their multiple identities, will be supported, both in their professional and personal development.

Although the DHE of MESY is not involved in the design of the curricula of the programmes of study offered by the HEIs, a recent mapping of the courses on human rights offered and the available personnel with expertise in human rights education (undertaken by the DHE) showed that the HEIs offer specific courses/programmes for human rights. Also, they have personnel with expertise in related subjects.

Offering language programmes is another way through which HEIs promote multiculturalism in Higher Education. HEIs in Cyprus offer courses in multiple languages, including Greek, Turkish, and English, to accommodate the linguistic diversity of the student population. Two of the Public Universities, namely UCY and CUT, operate Language Centres. The University of Cyprus also offers programmes, events and activities in Chinese language, culture, arts and business offered by the Confucius Institute, a non-profit organization and a joint venture between the Chinese International Education Foundation, ICY and the Beijing Institute of Education (<https://www.ucy.ac.cy/confucius/>).

The Examination Service of the DHE conducts the Examination for the Certification of Greek Language the six levels of the Common European Framework of Reference for Languages of the Council of Europe, among which levels A2 and B1, necessary for immigrants living in Cyprus according to the Civil Registry (Amendment) Law of 2023.

Furthermore, to address discrimination and promote anti-racism, HEIs in Cyprus have established anti-racism frameworks and codes of conduct. These frameworks include the operation of offices or committees responsible for handling complaints of discrimination, conducting training on diversity and inclusion, and ensuring compliance with anti-discrimination policies. Also, HEIs offer regular training and awareness programmes to educate students, faculty, and staff about discrimination and the importance of embracing diversity. These programs aim to create a more inclusive campus culture and equip individuals with the skills to recognize and combat discriminatory behaviours. At the same time, HEIs implement their own procedures to ensure that students with disabilities participate in all aspects of university life, i.e. education, learning facilities (classrooms, labs), resources, and extracurricular programmes.

HEIs in Cyprus offer multiple and flexible learning pathways for ensuring equality of opportunities, equal treatment and supporting the inclusion of all learners in learning processes:

- *Lifelong Learning and Continuing Education*

Continuing Professional Development programs are offered, aiming at professionals looking to update their skills or gain new qualifications. These programs are often flexible in terms of delivery mode (e.g., part-time, online). Short Courses and Workshops are targeted at individuals seeking to enhance specific skills or knowledge without committing to a full

degree program. Successful completion of these courses can sometimes be counted towards formal qualifications.

- *Distance and Online Learning*

The Open University of Cyprus, which is a public University, as well as several private HEIs offer distance programmes to students, facilitating entry into HE for students whose age or personal circumstances do not align with conventional in-person learning. This flexibility is particularly beneficial for mature students, working adults, international students, and those with family commitments. HEIs offer programmes as well, based on blended learning, combining online and face-to-face instruction, providing a flexible approach that caters to different learning styles and schedules.

- *Institutional Support for Flexible Learning*

HEIs in Cyprus provide academic and career counselling to support students to plan their educational pathways.

- *Recognition, Validation, and Accreditation of Non-formal and Informal Learning*

Cyprus is in the process of establishing procedures for the recognition, validation and accreditation of non-formal and informal learning.

- *Policy Frameworks*

The National Qualification Framework (CyQF) aligns with the European Qualifications Framework, facilitating the recognition and transfer of qualifications across Europe. The Cyprus Agency of Quality Assurance and Accreditation in HE (CYQAA), the competent authority responsible for all matters of quality assurance in HE, has established procedures and criteria (Quality Assurance Mechanisms) so that the programs of study offered by the HEIs comply with the European policy for mobility and mutual qualification recognition. In the same time, Cyprus is in the process of establishing procedures for the recognition, validation and accreditation of non-formal and informal learning.

- In general, what challenges were encountered in the implementation of non-discrimination and equal opportunities principles in education? If needed, brief quantitative information may be added.

The Antiracist Policy School Network, employing an intersectional approach, identifies and aims to empower teachers and schools in dealing with challenges that relate to the implementation of antiracist policies not only in Cyprus but across the world: the under-reporting of racist incidents, the need for accountability on behalf of organizations and individuals, the development of contextually appropriate pedagogical interventions based on the racisms operating in each context and, the constant awareness of the continually changing and evolving racisms across the globe.

Other relevant general measures, including gender equality

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|---|---|
| ✓ Legislation provides for gender equality in education | ✓ All barriers for pregnant girls and young mothers in education are eliminated to ensure the continuity of their education |
| ✓ Policy measures aim to enhance gender equality | ✓ Re-entry programmes for young mothers are provided for |
| ✓ Gender-responsive education sector planning is undertaken | |

- | | |
|---|--|
| ✓ Providing positive or affirmative action measures | ✓ Ensuring safe and adequate gender-sensitive sanitation facilities²⁰ |
| ☐ Providing financial incentives and fellowships | ✓ Curricula are rid of all stereotypes²¹ and bias |
| ✓ Teachers are trained (initial and in-service) on gender equality | ✓ Ensuring gender parity in science, technology, engineering and mathematics (STEM) |
| ✓ Teachers are trained to combat stigmatisation¹⁹ | ✓ Ensuring gender parity in technical and vocational training education and training (TVET) |
| ☐ Other: | |

- Please elaborate and, where appropriate, indicate the legal and policy measures taken:

Policy Statement

The Ministry of Education, Sport and Youth (MESY) has signed a Policy Statement on Gender Equality. This Declaration is a document which is a practical commitment of the Ministry, to take measures to ensure the principle of gender equality among its staff and among anyone affected by its activities, for example students.

Within this framework, the following actions are in progress:

- ***Establishment of a national committee/mechanism to promote cultural pluralism and respect for diversity***

The MESY is focused on ensuring equal opportunities in education for all genders on a non-discriminatory basis at all levels of education. Towards this end, it has formed an Interdepartmental Committee with representatives from all its departments and services. This Committee oversees and coordinates all gender equality issues related to actions taken.

The work of the Committee focuses on the development of an Action Plan, every three years, targeting gender equality in the structures of the educational system and the teacher in-service training. The Gender Equality Action Plan is a set of objectives, actions and commitments aiming at promoting a gender equality culture through sustainable ways in multiple levels, such as training different target groups (i.e., students, teachers, parents), research (i.e., integration of gender equality dimension in research projects for which the MOESY is the coordinator or partner), and relevant processes involved.

The Committee's work and actions includes:

- Conducting surveys on the needs and aspirations of women of 'diverse' cultural background and of their children as well as creating educational/professional structures aimed at providing language skills and professional orientation.
- Research and documentation of the needs and expectations of women of various cultural groups (foreign speakers and unaccompanied refugees).

¹⁹ ' Stigmatisation is the act of treating someone or something unfairly by publicly disapproving of them' (Cambridge Dictionary).

²⁰ ' Gender-sensitive sanitation includes clean, safe and separate toilets, with access to water and garbage disposal' ([UNGEI blog post](#), Gender-sensitive sanitation, 2018)

²¹ Stereotype is a set idea that people have about what someone or something is like, especially an idea that is wrong' (Cambridge Dictionary).

- Updating/enriching the webpage on the site of the Cyprus Pedagogical Institute relevant to gender equality issues
- Organizing specialized lessons in Greek language and career orientation for women of various cultural groups based on the findings of the research mentioned above.
- Promoting culture of acceptance and inclusion practices especially in regard to various culture groups within the school unit.
- Reshaping of Secondary Technical and Vocational Education with the aim of attracting female participation.
- The All-day School which allows pupils to extend their stay in school studying and being activated in other cultural, sporting, STEAM and other educational activities.
- Preventing and combating violence and delinquency in school and in the family.

Furthermore, every year the Interdepartmental Committee, in collaboration with the “Gender Equality Committee in Employment and Vocational Training” launches a writing competition related to gender equality for students in primary and secondary education. The competition often asks for written pieces that fit a certain theme or even follow a prompt. For example, the competition launched for the school year 2022-2023 was asking students to write a descriptive text or essay following a certain prompt: “We envision a school where all children are equally treated regardless of their gender, where they are given equal opportunities and rights, while they feel protected and free. Describe that school explaining the ways all persons in that school try to make that vision a reality”.

In addition, representatives of the Interdepartmental Committee for gender equality often participate in several meetings and/or training sessions related to the promotion of gender equality in the educational system as well as in society in general.

The Interdepartmental Committee’s work and actions are made public through the Committee’s website, hosted by the Cyprus Pedagogical Institute, in which among others, useful information regarding the Committee’s actions as well as teaching material for promoting equal opportunities and gender mainstreaming in the educational process is presented

(https://www.pi.ac.cy/pi/index.php?option=com_content&view=article&id=910&Itemid=383&lang=el).

➤ ***Ensure effective implementation of the National Action Plan for Gender Equality through the curriculum of various subjects***

The establishment of modern educational materials which will include a gender perspective aimed at combating gender stereotypes from an early age, especially by encouraging boys’ greater involvement in family life and women’s participation in politics/public life and develop relationships based on gender equality and mutual respect between the sexes.

One example is that in the Biology book of A’ Lyceum (for students aged 15-16 years old) in Unit 2 “Introduction to the genetic material” a number of references is hosted about the major input of women in science progress. A special reference is also included about the role of Rosaline Frankline in the discovery of the structure of the DNA double helix. Students are encouraged to write project-based reports about the role of women in the development of science from the 17th century until today in the topic of «Ethics in science».

➤ ***Empowering women/empowerment programmes and achieve equality between men and women in all areas***

The development of active citizenship with emphasis on social solidarity’ is a major objective of education in Cyprus. The development of actions targeting all forms of stereotyping, and

in particular that of eliminating the gap between men and women, falls within the framework of promoting this objective.

Within this framework, an interdisciplinary conference for teachers of all levels is organized to inform and discuss about gender equality in education. Furthermore, active participation of both sexes in mixed group assignments, school activities as well as the student councils is promoted and encouraged (quotation for the participation of both sexes). Additionally, all students are informed and encouraged to choose their study program without limitations or stereotypes.

The Department of Secondary Education has implemented a guide for Secondary Education teachers called “Actions for reducing the wage gap between men and women”. The guide deals with combating occupational segregation based on gender. Additionally, a guide published regarding the management of domestic violent incidents has been implemented in secondary education schools. This Guide is published by the Advisory Committee for the Prevention and Handling of Violence in the Family.

Increasing the participation of girls and women in Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET) programmes by changing the widely accepted perception that TVET is a male-dominated educational pathway, leading to male-dominated professions is one of the priorities of the Department of Secondary Technical and Vocational Education and Training. In order to combat this misconception and break the gender stereotypes regarding this type of education, the Department takes various measures, such as campaigns aiming to inform prospective female students about the opportunities provided by TVET programmes for enhanced employability.

The Department of Higher Education (DHE) of the MESY is involved in the design and implementation of a 3-year Action Plan aiming to enhance Gender Equality. In the same time, the DHE promotes issues concerning Gender Equality at HEIs of Cyprus. During the academic year 2021-2022, the Department has taken steps for the collection of both qualitative and quantitative data through the development of an online platform on various aspects of Higher Education (HE) in Cyprus (e.g. student population, academic/teaching staff, programs of study etc.) from all Higher Educational Institutions (HEIs) in Cyprus on a yearly basis. Data collection involves, among other, gender disaggregated data regarding the student population and academic/teaching staff in HEIs alongside other indicators (such as level of study, field of study for student population) to develop initial baseline assessment, but also to be able to evaluate progress on gender equality in terms of access and participation in HE. In the context of the annual report of DHE on mapping the field of HE in Cyprus, a separate chapter will be devoted to gender participation in HE. This systematic gathering and analysis of data will provide the necessary evidence to evaluate and explore whether gender equality works and where it works and thus inform decision-makers regarding existing inequalities. The DHE has also developed a comprehensive National Graduate Tracking Mechanism that generates high quality and comparable data on a longitudinal basis from graduates of all genders in all HEIs in Cyprus, regarding their career paths after obtaining their qualifications in HE by combining survey and administrative data. The online platform and the National Graduate Tracking Mechanism will provide valid and reliable data to estimate statistical indicators and track progress on various dimensions regarding gender equality.”

The MESY has developed a policy in 2018, which defines the use of a non-sexist language in all Ministry documents. The policy is implemented through a guide called “Guide for the Transcendence of Language Sexism in the Language of the Documents of the Public Administration of the Republic of Cyprus”.

➤ ***Promoting gender equality through STEAM education programs***

All students are informed and are encouraged to participate in STEAM activities without limitations or stereotypes. More specifically the following actions are undertaken/promoted:

- Equal participation of both sexes in Science education activities.
- Extension of the inclusion of STEAM education programs in schools with equal participation of both sexes
- Teachers training in STEAM education in order to promote gender equality through the activities.
- All parents are informed about STEAM education and its benefits for the society
- Active participation of both sexes in mixed group STEAM activities
- Implementation of STEAM education in the curriculum of primary and secondary schools.
- Encourage girls to participate in STEAM fairs and competitions.
- Girls are informed and encouraged by school counsellors to choose their future occupation without limitations or stereotypes.
- Establishing modern STEAM education materials including a gender perspective aimed at combating gender stereotypes from an early age.
- Organize several activities in the school unit (debates, dramas, art exhibition, talent shows) to promote gender equality and inclusion.
- Participation in programs promoting gender equality and inclusion for example the «The Mediterranean Institute of Gender Studies».
- Establishing educational material for teachers to inform about gender equality.
- Inspectors and teachers training through seminars about gender equality, sex education and inclusion.
- Organize workshops/ seminars for teachers/ parents and students about gender equality within the field of national and European programs.

➤ ***Sexuality Education***

Sexuality Education (SD) is part of the Health Education Curriculum (HEC), which is taught in Primary Education through the Health Education course and in Secondary General Education through the Health Education (Home Economics) course, since 2011 (in Gymnasium and in two grades of the Lyceum as an elective). According to the "Law for Holistic Sexuality Education of 2022" (Law 205(I)/2022) dated December 2, 2022, during the current school year 2023-2024, Sexuality Education is offered to all Lyceum and Technical school students with six (6) teaching periods per school year.

The purpose of this Law is to develop a framework for mandatory holistic sexual education, through the syllabus in all classes and at all levels of public and private education.

Sexuality education, as included in Health Education, may contribute to the prevention and dealing of social problems such as sexual violence, bullying, unwanted pregnancies in teenagers, homophobia, risky sexual behaviours, HIV/AIDS and other STDs, reproduction of gender stereotypes, violence against women, stigmatization and discrimination of marginalized groups such as LGBT pupils etc. Based on the methodological approach of Health Education, sexuality education is approached in a way that no pupil, from any background, will feel insulted, excluded or uncomfortable during the lesson. On the contrary, each pupil is empowered through their own cultural and ethical framework in order to acquire the skills

and adopt the attitudes, values and behaviours which enhance their resistance to the early initiation of sexual activities and/or involvement in high-risk sexual behaviours.

The learning objectives of sexuality education in the Health Education Curriculum aim to the promotion of critical analysis perspectives on issues of sexuality and not to a moralistic position in favour or against any choice of sexual behaviour. Sexuality education, based on the Health Education Curriculum, does not aim to teach what is "right" or "wrong" in relation to family planning and sexual life - and it is offered always in the context of international, European and national legal framework and of the International Declaration of Human Rights. Learning objectives are based on the health promotion approach and aim to provide opportunities to pupils in order to critically explore the various social factors which determine issues of sexuality, and to understand the ways in which society may influence the attitudes, choices and behaviours of a person in relation to sexuality issues.

The CPI continues to support teachers with multiple types of teacher training on the Health Education Curriculum every year, such as series of trainings for primary and secondary education teachers on teaching sexuality education through the implementation of the Health Education curriculum, workshops for pupils and teachers of secondary education on issues of sexting and sexual abuse etc.

➤ ***Cyprus Observatory on School Violence (COSV)***

The MESY has designed and developed the National Strategy for Preventing and addressing School Violence, which has a four-year timeframe of implementation (2018 -2024). According to its role and responsibilities, and based on the aforementioned Strategy, the COSV has developed and implemented actions that aim to prevent and address bullying and violence at schools. The COSV provides support to school units for the implementation of actions and programmes aimed at improving the school climate, with the ultimate aim of reducing violence at schools. These programmes, run on an annual basis and are school-based, are the "Conflict Resolution - School Mediation" and the "Recognition and Management of School Bullying". The COSV supports schools in the implementation of anti-bullying programmes, which deal with recognizing, preventing and combating bullying. With "Conflict Resolution - School Mediation" schools are encouraged to find effective ways of resolving pupils' conflicts as well as alternative ways of managing conflict situations at school. In 2023, 104 schools were supported and 4008 teachers and 300 parents were trained by COSV.

Guidelines on how to handle conflicts or bullying were produced and disseminated at the training courses. Also, educational material to assist teachers on how to undertake activities with children to enhance their competences needed for prevention and management of school violence was produced and disseminated. The curriculum of this material includes activities to enhance anger management, team building, empathy, emotional intelligence, social and communicative skills, tolerance, acceptance of diversity, mediation skills, anti-bullying skills, conflict management etc.

The COSV also monitored a national-level research that investigates the phenomenon of violence at schools. The research aims to collect data about violence in education, from all schools of all levels in Cyprus, for three consecutive years, with the participation of teachers, parents and students.

Moreover, the COSV collects data concerning good practices for the prevention of violence in schools, it evaluates these practices, and it organizes an annual conference where the best practices are awarded, thus receiving visibility and outreach. It also collaborates with other stakeholders involved in preventing and responding to school violence. Additionally, COSV organizes school based seminars related to the prevention and management of violence and delinquency. During the school year 2022-2023, 25 schools (2 kindergartens, 21 primary schools and 2 secondary schools) received such training and support.

In addition, the COSV participates as a partner in the Erasmus+ KA3 project titled "SAFER: Social competences and Fundamental Rights for preventing bullying (including on-line bullying)" (December 2020-November 2023). This project aims to experiment with the innovative method of "Whole School and Community Approach" in preventing and combating bullying.

National Action Plan

Gender equality in education is a major part in the National Action Plan that was created by the collaboration of all ministries in Cyprus. More specifically, there are three actions in this Action Plan which are focusing on these issues:

- 1) Enriching the content of curricula with actions that promote empathy, gender equality and prevention of violence against women.
- 2) Training seminars for Counseling and Vocational Education teachers and other teachers for deconstructing gender stereotypes and promoting gender equality.
- 3) Restructuring of the Cyprus history books to include the role of women in the history of Cyprus.

- What challenges were encountered in achieving gender equality in and through education? If needed, brief quantitative information may be added.

Gender equality in education is not an easy task. Challenges are encountered throughout this process. The most important difficulty is the resistance of teachers, principals, parents as well as student to change stereotyped beliefs and/or attitudes that are well-bounded. Gender stereotypes which concern generalised views or preconceptions about attributes, or characteristics that are or ought to be possessed by women and men or the roles that are or should be performed by men and women, as well as social norms and cultural practices used based on those stereotypes, are only some of the biggest challenges to gender equality in education, not to mention several cultural norms and practices and/or school-related gender-based violence.

Despite the efforts of the Department of Secondary Technical and Vocational Education and Training, the majority of students attending technical and vocational education and training programmes are still predominantly male.

In the same time, it seems that there are stereotypes among students and parents resulting in the choices of the field of study in Higher Education, as indicated in some doctoral studies. However, further and more specific research on the topic needs to be done.

- Does the legal minimum age for marriage conform to international standards (18 years) ²²:

Please note that child marriage is a discriminatory practice as often girls can marry at a younger age than boys. Child marriage violates the child's right to education as they are more likely to drop out of school and children who are not in school are more likely to get married.

☒ Yes ☐ No

- Please provide reference to the relevant laws and provisions and indicate the exceptions to the legal age of marriage as well as the absolute minimum age:

National minorities:

For reference: Article/Paragraph 5(1)(c) of the Convention/Recommendation provides for the rights of national minorities.

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|--|--|
| ✓ Legislation provides for the right to education of national minorities | ✓ Teachers are trained on intercultural education |
| ✓ Policy measures aim to enhance the right to education of national minorities | ✓ Teachers are trained to combat stigmatisation²⁴ |
| ☐ Policy elaboration includes consultations with local communities | Ö Multilingual and intercultural education are supported |
| ✓ The right to carry out their own educational activities is legally guaranteed for national minorities | Ö Native language instruction is ensured for national minorities |
| ☐ Educational standards are established for educational institutions run by national minorities | Ö Adapting curricula and teaching and learning methods to their needs for national minorities |
| ☐ Positive or affirmative action measures are provided for national minorities | ☐ Curricula are rid of all stereotypes ²⁵ and bias |
| ✓ Financial incentives and fellowships are provided for national minorities | |
| ☐ Other ²³ : | |

- Please elaborate and, where appropriate, indicate the legal and policy measures taken:

- What challenges were encountered in realizing the right to education of minorities? If needed, brief quantitative information may be added.

Indigenous people:

²³ Please see: [UNESCO report](#) 'The right to education of minorities: Overview of States' measures reported in the 10th Consultation on the 1960 Convention and Recommendation against Discrimination in Education, 2023.

²⁴ Supra note 15.

²⁵ Supra note 16.

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Legislation provides for the right to education of indigenous people | ☐ Financial incentives and fellowships are provided for indigenous people |
| ☐ Policy measures aim to enhance the right to education of indigenous people | ☐ Teachers are trained on intercultural education |
| ☐ Policy elaboration includes consultations with local communities | ☐ Teachers are trained to combat stigmatisation ²⁶ |
| ☐ The right to carry out their own educational activities is legally guaranteed for indigenous people | ☐ Multilingual and intercultural education are supported |
| ☐ Educational standards are established for educational institutions run by indigenous people | ☐ Native language instruction is ensured |
| ☐ Positive or affirmative action measures are provided for indigenous people | ☐ Adapting curricula and teaching and learning methods to their needs for indigenous people |
| ☐ Other: | ☐ Curricula are rid of all stereotypes ²⁷ and bias |

- Please elaborate and, where appropriate, indicate the legal and policy measures taken:

For the Republic of Cyprus the term “national minorities” designates only those minority-groups which had a traditional presence on the island at the time of the establishment of the Republic of Cyprus in 1960 and hold the Cypriot citizenship. Thus, “religious groups”, as defined in article 2(3) of the Constitution, are treaded as national minorities. Consequently, with the term religious group we refer to Armenians, Maronites and Latins (Roman Catholic) citizens of the Republic of Cyprus who at the time of establishment of the Republic of Cyprus in 1960 opted in accordance with its Constitution to be part of the Greek Community (Article 2, paragraph 3 of the Constitution).

The right to education for all children is safeguarded by Article 20 of the Constitution of the Republic of Cyprus. Moreover, the equality of all children enrolled in schools is guaranteed by the legislation. The regulations for the operation of public secondary schools clearly state that any person or public authority involved in the interpretation or implementation of the regulations is obliged to refrain from “any discrimination based on race, colour, gender, language, religion, political and other beliefs of the child or his/her parents or guardians, citizenship, ethnic or social origin, economic situation, disability, birth, sexual orientation or any other situation”. Thus, any discriminatory attitudes based on religion or belief are strictly forbidden.

The educational needs of the three religious groups are supported by the Ministry of Education, Sport and Youth (MESY) that has an earmarked budget specifically for them. There is a different degree of autonomy in educational issues and each religious group has its own schools based on their needs and goals.

The educational needs of the Armenians are mainly supported though the operation of the Armenian Nareg Schools that are fully subsidized by the MESY. Armenian Nareg Schools are public schools that follow a differentiate program since the Armenian language, history, geography and religion are taught. The Armenian Nareg schools promote the Armenian

²⁶ Supra note 15.

²⁷ Supra note 16.

identity in extra-curricular activities, such as, the offering of Armenian dance and music lessons. Furthermore, the MESY has as a different budget for the operation of the Armenian School Board.

The educational needs of the Maronites are supported in “Agios Maronas” Pre-Primary and Primary School that are fully subsidized by the MESY. The “Agios Maronas” Pre-Primary and Primary School, is a public school with a high attendance of pupils that belong to the Maronite religious group. The MESY subsidizes the transportation of Maronite children to the school.

Regarding the children belonging to the religious groups that choose to attend private schools, the MESY subsidizes their tuition fees. The subsidization is significantly higher for Maronite and Latin children attending Terra Santa College and St Mary’s School, the private schools that are particularly affiliated with these groups.

The Republic of Cyprus after signing the European Charter for Regional or Minority Languages recognised the Armenian language and Cypriot Maronite Arabic (CMA) as minority languages of the Republic of Cyprus. To this end, Armenian language is supported in Armenian Nareg Schools and CMA is safeguarded in “Agios Maronas” Pre-Primary and Primary School, a public school with a high attendance of pupils that belong to the Maronite religious group. The Ministry also supports the organisation of training seminars for teachers of the Armenian language and CMA, as well as the rest of the staff of the Armenian and Maronite schools. Additionally, the MESY subsidizes the purchase and production of books and teaching material for both languages.

Separate teaching periods regarding the history, culture, language, religion and identity of the three religious groups of Cyprus i.e. national minorities are included in the History subject in secondary education. In particular, the curriculum contains proposed activities for the designing of projects by pupils and a list of monuments is included for the organisation of planned visits by the teachers, thus promoting the better understanding of the history of the religious groups in Cyprus. Additionally, the curriculum specifically mentions that through the teaching of history pupils are expected to develop respect for religious and cultural differences. Towards this end 15 short videos were produced by Cyprus Broadcasting Corporation have been uploaded on the website of the MESY. These videos promote the identity and culture of the religious groups and provide overall awareness to the general public about their history, religion, values and contribution to the Cypriot society.

Moreover, in “Agios Maronas” Pre-Primary and Primary School (public school with a high attendance of pupils that belong to the Maronite religious group) the existing curriculum of public schools that includes specific attainment and adequacy indicators in all subjects is followed. At the same time, the curriculum in History, Religious Education and Geography is enriched with content of specific interest to Maronites to cover aspects of the Maronite catholic religion, the history and culture of the Maronite community, for grades 1-6. Based on the enriched curriculum new teaching material was developed that covers aspects of the Maronite catholic religion, history, geography, and culture.

- What challenges were encountered in realizing the right to education of indigenous people? If needed, brief quantitative information may be added.

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People on the move (migrants, refugees, asylum-seekers, stateless persons and internally displaced persons) and trapped populations²⁸:

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|---|--|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> ✓ Legislation provides for their right to education ✓ Policy measures aim to enhance their right to education ✓ Inclusion in mainstream schools is ensured ✓ Positive or affirmative action measures are provided for ☐ All administrative barriers to access education are removed ✓ Alternative administrative procedures (placement tests, portfolio of evidence, etc.) to overcome administrative barriers²⁹ are provided for ✓ Teachers are specifically trained to ensure their inclusion ✓ Teachers are trained to combat stigmatisation³⁰ ☐ Other: | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> ☐ Financial incentives and fellowships are provided for ✓ Auxiliary assistance is provided ✓ Multiple and flexible learning pathways³¹ are provided ✓ Curricula are rid of all stereotypes³² and bias ✓ Accelerated learning programmes are provided ✓ Non-formal and/or alternative education programmes are provided ✓ Language classes to newcomers are provided for ✓ Multilingualism and intercultural education are encouraged |
|---|--|

- Please elaborate and, where appropriate, indicate the legal and policy measures taken:

The Ministry of Education, Sport and Youth (MESY) has developed and implemented an upgraded educational policy pertaining to Intercultural Education, aiming at the smooth integration of pupils/students from diverse ethnic backgrounds into the educational system of Cyprus.

The Policy Paper (2016) was prepared by an Interdepartmental Committee and approved by the Minister of Education. The Policy Paper covers key issues related to the reception and integration of students with migrant backgrounds at the macro-, the meso- and the micro-level. According to the taxonomy suggested in a European Commission Report (NESSE, 2008) the macro-level refers to the society and the educational system and thus to the formulation of the educational policy expressed in the policy paper, the meso-level focuses on the school and the interaction between the individual and society in the school context and the micro-level refers to the school classroom and the interaction and relations between teachers,

²⁸ 'Trapped populations are those who are unable to migrate to safe locations and remain trapped in locations vulnerable to the impacts of climate hazards' ([UNESCO report](#): The impact of climate displacement on the right to education, 2020, p. 2).

²⁹ While lack of documentation (such as identity papers, birth certificates, residency permits, etc.) should not be an obstacle to access education, these can constitute a barrier to education See: [UNESCO publication](#): Handbook on the right to education, 2018, p. 96.

³⁰ Supra note 15.

³¹ Supra note 13

³² Supra note 16.

students, and parents. Through the Policy Paper the Ministry declares its commitment to the smooth integration of pupils with a migrant background into the Cyprus educational system. It actually provides a framework for every action and activity which falls within the Cyprus educational system in respect to the issue of the integration of pupils with migrant backgrounds. The policy focuses on five priority areas: (1) learning the Greek language, (2) reception of newly arrived children with migrant background, (3) education and teachers' in-service training, (4) data collection and analysis of the needs of pupils/students with a migrant background and (5) intercultural approach in the new curricula. The document also describes the current state of affairs regarding the integration of children with migrant backgrounds in the Cyprus Educational System as well as the teaching of Greek as a second language. Based on the Policy Paper action plans have been developed and implemented covering the different pillars of the policy paper. In addition to that, in cooperation with the European Commission Directorate on Education a peer counseling event took place in March 2019. The final report submitted in July 2019 consisted of 21 recommendations. The recommendations focus mainly on the reception phase per se, for supporting all significant others in the school role set of migrant students. There were also recommendations for the schools as institutions seeking autonomy and flexibility, the policy-makers and the anti-racist policy.

The work that the Cyprus Pedagogical Institute (CPI) and the Interdepartmental Committee have done based on the Policy Paper and the Peer Counseling Report can be described shortly as follows:

- Supporting teachers and schools dealing with integration of students with migrant backgrounds via:
 - Teachers' networks for pre-primary, primary and secondary education (online seminars and communication via the CPI's Moodle platform, seminars etc)
 - School-based seminars
 - Optional-based seminars in afternoon time
- The CPI's website on the educational integration of students with migrant backgrounds
- Reception Guides for primary and secondary education
- Translation of school and family communication forms in several first languages of migrant children
- Unified Curriculum for Greek as a Second Language (pre-primary, primary, secondary education)
- Teaching materials for teaching Greek as a second language in primary education
- Useful materials (e.g. survival language cards, basic daily classroom instructions in pictures)
- that support schools in their efforts for the reception of students with migrant backgrounds

- Questionnaires for parents to collect useful data for the children (website and reception guides)
- Initial, midterm and final assessment tests for Greek as a second language
- Diagnostic tests in different first languages of students with migrant backgrounds in Maths and Science (Biology, Physics)
- Guide for parent mediators - Instructions for the cooperation of school and parents - mediators
- Guide to managing socio-cultural diversity
- Erasmus+ KA3 project "PASSAGE - Pedagogies of Passing from Reception to Education" (2021 - 2023)

Regarding linguistic support of pupils with migrant and refugee background, various models have been adopted in the Cypriot education system in recent years. The following activities have been undertaken:

➤ ***Lessons of Greek as a Second Language in Primary Education Schools***

Students with migrant background attend lessons of Greek as a Second Language, following official and formative evaluation for a period of two years in specialised classes. Beginning from the current school year 2021-2022 major changes have been implemented aiming an increased number of hours offered to all students. There are two major schemes applied in Primary Education:

- Schools under the DRASE+ programme: 92 primary schools offer a minimum of 10 hours per week to each group of students
- Other schools: offer a minimum of 5 hours per week to each group of students

➤ ***Intensive Learning Programme of Greek as a Second Language in Secondary Education Schools are offered under various schemes****

- Transitional Classes: In the 24 Gymnasiums and 8 Lyceums with a large number of students with migrant and refugee background, students receive Language instruction for 14 hours per week, plus 5 hours for support in Mathematics and Science for a period of two years.
- For schools with a small number of migrant students, fewer hours are provided: students receive language instruction for 5-8 hours per week for two years.
- For unaccompanied minors/applicants for international protection a special programme is implemented in five schools (six lyceums and two technical schools) that includes intensive teaching of the Greek language (14-16 periods per week), as well as other core course subjects and workshops.
- In the 26 secondary and technical schools participating in the DRASE+ programme, students are supported by the presence of a teacher assistant during regular/common core classes.

**The above-mentioned programs are obligatory to all students registered in public schools. Attendance problems are reported in higher education, especially for unaccompanied minors.*

In addition to the above, in September 2020, the “Syllabus for Greek as a second language (Pre-primary, Primary, Secondary, Technical and Vocational Education of Cyprus)” has been published and notified to all schools. It is a unified curriculum for all levels of education including indicators for language and academic skills, through a cross-cultural perspective:

- Offering Greek language courses - in the afternoon - from the Adult Education Centres and the State Institutes of Further Education of the MESY for both minor and adult students
- Offering free Greek language courses through the “Greek Language Program and Mediation Services for Minor Third-Country Nationals” («Μαθαίνω ελληνικά!»). Through this program, primary school students receive after class lessons throughout the school year, while secondary education students during the summer.

In primary education around 16% of the pupil population speak Greek as their second language. As of September 2021, the support teaching of the Greek language has been redesigned, following one of the recommendations of the European Commission’s (2019) peer counselling activity. The number of teaching periods for learning the Greek language has considerably been increased in all primary schools, so that pupils learn the language for free at an adequate level and the programme becomes more effective. The Adult Education Centres also provide lessons free of charge to pupils with a migrant background for learning the Greek language, after school hours. The Centers also offer courses to migrant adults to learn the Greek language, as well as courses to Greek and Turkish Cypriot adults to learn the Turkish and Greek languages, respectively.

Regarding school education (primary, secondary, vocational), it should be stressed that second language teaching for migrants is part of a whole-school approach as promoted in the Action Plan of Interdepartmental Committee for the integration of pupils with a migrant background in the Cyprus Educational System.

Some of the Higher Education Institutions in Cyprus offer free language courses for learning Greek to migrants. For example, the School of Modern Greek of the University of Cyprus offers Greek language courses to immigrants residing in Cyprus, Turkish Cypriots, non-Greek speaking residents of Cyprus, and asylum seekers. Civil Refugees / Political Refugees in a Complementary Protection Scheme and Turkish Cypriots are exempted from paying fees. Additionally, the Examination Service of the Department of Higher Education conducts the Examination for the Certification of Greek Language the six levels of the Common European Framework of Reference for Languages of the Council of Europe, among which levels A2 and B1, necessary for immigrants living in Cyprus according to the Civil Registry (Amendment) Law of 2023.

The needs of students attending pre-primary schools are addressed through differentiated instruction within the curriculum. In the 52 pre-primary schools participating in the DRASE+ program, this effort is reinforced by the presence of a teacher assistant for 10 hours per week. As part of the “Syllabus for Greek as a second language”, the “Supplementary Progression Framework for Pre-Primary Education” is applied complementing the official syllabus. Kindergarten classrooms are ideal learning environments for pupils with a migrant background at an age when the innate language acquisition mechanism is fully activated. Children learn and socialize not only in interaction with their teachers, but mainly with their peers through play which is the basic method of building their knowledge, spiritual and

emotional development. As a result, the language of instruction is sufficiently mastered before entering primary school.

Moreover, the following measures are implemented to further support children with migrant background:

➤ ***Interdepartmental Committee for the integration of pupils with a migrant background in the Cyprus Educational System***

After the introduction and the implementation of the new policy for the integration of pupils with a migrant background and for teaching Greek as a second language, an Interdepartmental Committee was established and an action plan is being implemented, in order to achieve the Committee's goals for the integration of pupils.

➤ ***System for mapping the migrant pupil population***

The Centre of Educational Research and Evaluation (CERE) is operating a common data entry and data processing platform, to create a flexible and easy-to-use system for mapping the pupil population. The data collected for migrant pupils are: parent's country of origin, year of entry in Cyprus, whether pupils speak Greek at an adequate level and whether pupils currently participate in remedial classes (and if yes for how many years) or need to participate in the following school year.

➤ ***Educational material for teaching Greek as a second language***

Appropriate educational material has been prepared and was sent to schools to help teachers in their teaching.

➤ ***Teacher trainings***

- On intercultural education and teaching Greek as a second language (2019-today): School Support Networks for pre-primary and primary education teachers for the teaching of Greek as a second language.
- On the implementation of the anti-racist policy (2018-today): School Support Networks (primary and secondary education) for the implementation of the policy.

➤ ***Curriculum and syllabus for teaching Greek as a second language (2020)***

Introduction of a new unified curriculum and syllabus for teaching Greek as a second language, covering all levels of education (pre-primary, primary and secondary).

➤ ***Validation and distribution of diagnostic tests (2016-today)***

A central assessment programme is implemented by the CERE in order to identify Greek language level of pupils with a migrant background for primary education. The CERE distributes Greek language competence tests for the classification of pupils of primary education at levels, based on the Common European Framework of Reference for Languages. Pupils are then placed in small groups to attend a specific number of lessons per week.

➤ ***Tools for continuous assessment in language and other subject skills***

Implementation of tools for continuous assessment of children's with a migrant background Greek language learning (initial, intermediate and final assessment), as well as translated tools for assessing skills in Mathematics.

➤ ***Programme for migrant parents working in schools as cultural and language mediators (2017-today)***

In 2021 the MESY continued the implementation of the programme for migrant parents working in schools as cultural and language mediators, funded by the Asylum, Migration and Integration Fund and the Cyprus Government.

Apart from the measures mentioned above, which also apply for secondary education, it should also be stressed that many schools where migrant children are enrolled, participate in the project “School and Social Inclusion Actions” since 2015. The implementation of this project aims to support the population living below the poverty line or being at risk of poverty and social exclusion. It also aims at ensuring social welfare and supporting financially the weaker groups of the population that are particularly affected by the economic crisis, reducing early school leaving, improving learning outcomes and reducing school failure and delinquency. Various measures are implemented which include, among others, the employment of a second/ assistant teacher in order to overcome difficulties during the lesson. Moreover, programmes for reinforcing learning and creativity for pupils (during the morning, afternoon and summer months). In this framework theatre, dance, graffiti, poetry recital, athletic events and other activities are offered to students both in morning and afternoon hours. One major objective of the project is that participating schools could open their doors to their local communities, in order to develop cooperation and synergy with all stakeholders. In this context, Greek is taught as a second language in afternoon classes for both parents and students. Moreover, experts offered psychological support for both students and parents and training programmes for the staff involved. The project is co-funded by the European Social Fund.

Additionally to the above-mentioned actions, it is important to note that due to the ongoing increase of the number of Unaccompanied Minors / Applicants of International Protection and according to the relevant Ministers’ Decision (no. 87.593), an afternoon Educational Programme offering lessons in Greek as a Second Language and Mathematics is in operation at State Institutes of Training. This programme is offered to students who could not be hosted in the morning programmes due to shortage of places in schools (lyceums or technical schools).

The MESY, implementing the European directives for the education of all children, especially migrant children, has prepared a special programme for the education of unaccompanied migrant children. Within this context, Upper Secondary Technical and Vocational Education and Training programmes are offered to groups of unaccompanied migrant children, who attend Technical and Vocational Schools of Education and Training in Nicosia, Limassol and Larnaca districts. The programmes have been tailored to meet the needs of unaccompanied migrant children. As part of their one-year studies, they attend Greek language courses, as well as general education and technical and vocational education and training courses. Children who acquire a good level of knowledge of the Greek language can proceed to continue their education at the Evening Schools of Technical and Vocational Education, which operate as second chance schools. These schools offer formal upper Secondary Technical and Vocational Education programmes (EQF level 4) to adult learners who wish to obtain an upper Secondary School Leaving Certificate (Apolyterion). The Apolyterion entitles graduates either

to pursue further studies at Higher Education Institutions, provided that they meet the entry requirements, or access the labour market directly as skilled workers.

In addition to the above, in the context of the operation of the Lifelong Learning Programmes of Vocational Education and Training, the Department of Secondary Technical and Vocational Education and Training offers one-year and three-year training programmes in order to respond to the increasing need for continuous up-skilling and re-skilling throughout an individual's working life. The objective of these programmes is to offer lifelong learning opportunities for education and training to employed or unemployed adults, including migrants, in order to be able to respond more effectively to the contemporary demands of the labour market and enhance their integration in society. Even though learners pay limited fees approved by the Council of Ministers for attending these programmes, migrants who are asylum seekers can attend these programmes free of charge.

- Have specific measures been adopted for climate displaced persons?

☐ Yes ☐ No

- Please elaborate:

- What challenges were encountered in realizing the right to education of migrants, refugees, asylum seekers, stateless persons and IDPs? If needed, brief quantitative information may be added.

Upon the outbreak of the refugee crisis, the Cyprus educational system encountered various challenges in order to ensure the access to the right of education for all students. For instance, various problems that the Ministry had encountered were administrative challenges, shortages of classrooms and trained teachers, lack of training material, tools and resources to work with refugee and migrant children and various other educational challenges as a result of students' migratory lifestyles (for instance, cultural barriers, including language and communication barriers).

People with disabilities:

- | | |
|---|---|
| ✓ Legislation provides for their right to education | ✓ Mainstream teachers are specifically trained on disabilities |
| ✓ Policy measures aim to enhance their right to education | ✓ Teachers are trained to combat stigmatisation³³ |
| ✓ Inclusion in mainstream schools is ensured | ✓ Auxiliary assistance is provided |
| ☐ Special schools are used as resource centers to inclusive schools | ✓ Curricula and teaching and learning methods are adapted |
| ✓ Positive or affirmative action measures are provided | ✓ Curricula are rid of all stereotypes³⁴ and bias |

³³ Supra note 15.

³⁴ Supra note 16.

✓ **Financial incentives and fellowships are provided**

✓ **Education infrastructure and learning materials are adapted**

☐ Other

- Please elaborate and, where appropriate, indicate the legal and policy measures taken:

The United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UNCRPD) was signed by the Republic of Cyprus in 2007 and ratified in 2011. The inclusion of learners with special needs in mainstream education is a major policy matter for the Ministry of Education, Sport and Youth, in line with current international conventions and philosophical thought. The adoption of this policy has been accompanied by a change in perceptions, beliefs, and attitudes of society towards children with special needs, whether they are in the educational system or in the community.

The policy is expressed within the Education and Training of Children with Special Needs Laws of 1999-2020 and in the Education and Training of Children with Special Needs Regulations of 2001-2013. The legislative framework secures the children's right to education, regulates the procedures regarding the identification of children with special needs and their placement in the most appropriate setting as well as the facilities and resources needed to be provided in each case. Moreover, the legislation provides children with disabilities with all the opportunities for equal education, in order to develop their skills to the highest level and ensures that all learners with disabilities or special needs are included in the school environment and specific measures are promoted to cater for their individualised needs. The goal is that all learners have the right to be educated together, regardless of any special need or disability.

Furthermore, the Department of Social Inclusion of Persons with Disabilities, coordinated the preparation of the First National Disability Strategy 2018-2028 and the four National Disability Action Plans (2013-2015, 2018-2020, 2021-2023 and 2024-2028), with the aim of defining the vision, values, strategic goals and objectives of the Republic of Cyprus for the implementation of additional actions that further safeguard the rights of citizens with disabilities, in all areas of life.

The National Action Plan for Disability aims to provide support to all teachers of all levels in different ways. The Cyprus Pedagogical Institute, as the body responsible for the training of teachers of all levels, includes issues of disability education, inclusive and uniform education in the actions it offers. More specifically, the trainings aim to contribute to the recognition, dealing with and recording incidents of discrimination in schools based on disability as well as to the training and empowerment of teachers, parents and guardians on issues of inclusive education and disability.

See also our answer above, under 2.1 general measures on teacher training and dealing with racist incidents based on disability.

- What challenges were encountered in realizing the right to education of people with disabilities? If needed, brief quantitative information may be added.

After the enactment of the legislation, many children with special needs, who either dropped out of school or attended special schools, have been integrated into mainstream schools and continue their education smoothly, with all the accommodations they are entitled to for equal access to education. The philosophy of integrating children into mainstream schools was initially unfamiliar to teachers, but today, through seminars and training they receive, it has become fully understood and implementable.

The Republic of Cyprus has ratified international conventions and implements educational programmes and policies, which are based on contemporary educational approaches, seeking to change the culture and improve the legislative framework towards inclusive education. However, it was realised that more changes need to be made so as our educational system becomes more inclusive.

Ensuring equal access to and participation of all children in non-discriminatory and inclusive education is a key objective of the Ministry of Education, Sport and Youth (MESY), which respects and recognizes the diversity of each child, as well as its fundamental right to education.

In October 2023, the President of the Republic announced the initiation of a dialogue on the upgrading and pedagogical reform of special education. The MESY plans a legislative reform of its special education provision. The aim of the reform is to make the education system more inclusive, aligned with the priorities stated at European level and with the Cypriot commitment to the UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities.

Students from poor households:

✓ **Financial incentives and fellowships for school enrolment are provided**

☐ Teachers are trained to combat stigmatisation³⁵

✓ **Transport, meals and education material are subsidised or provided free of charge beyond compulsory education**

☐ Curricula are rid of all stereotypes³⁶ and bias

☐ Positive or affirmative action measures are provided

✓ **Other:**

Actions/Programmes supported by the Committee of Health Education and Citizenship (CHEC)

➤ *Grant of non-school-related actions to support pupils and pupils belonging to vulnerable population groups*

The Programme has been operating since 2012 and is part of the commitments of the Ministry of the Interior regarding the National Strategy for Addressing Addictions (2021 - 2028). The CHEC identifies and supports pupils who belong to vulnerable population groups (i.e. delinquent behavior, use of alcohol or illegal substances, smoking, families with extremely difficult economic conditions or with severe dysfunction - violence in the family, serious health problems of another member or of the child himself, residence in the Children's Home, a family member in prison, unemployment, alcoholism and so on.), to be engaged in creative employment activities that they choose themselves in the community, in non-school settings every year.

The actions aim at contributing to the essential support (learning, emotional, self- and social self-empowerment, highlighting and cultivating talent, developing a safe life and so on.) of pupils who belong to vulnerable population groups. A possible risk faced by the action is the social exclusion and marginalization of pupils of the specific categories due to their possible inability to participate in activities utilizing their free time and highlighting their special abilities / talents.

During the 2022 - 2023 school year, 787 actions, outside school time, were offered, which related to the support of pupils belonging to vulnerable population groups. During the 2023 - 2024 school year, 900 actions, outside school time, are offered

³⁵ Supra note 15.

³⁶ Supra note 16.

➤ ***"Web" programme (providing afternoon support services to vulnerable pupils, in Gymnasias and Lycea), in the framework of the cooperation of the Ministry of Education, Sport and Youth and the Cyprus National Addictions Authority***

The Programme aims at providing individualized multi-level support to pupils who face serious difficulties in their personal, family or school life and which may be related to the use of addictive substances. The provision of support is offered in particular through healthy afternoon activities, psycho-education, learning support or other services depending on the needs assessment of each case, with the ultimate goal to strengthen their personality, highlight their skills, change their behaviour and prevent the use of addictive substances or other harmful behaviours by creating a deterrent environment. The support is provided by social workers to pupils who are referred by the school administration, through healthy afternoon activities. The implementation of the Programme is the responsibility of the Cyprus National Addictions Authority, which after an open tender procedure assigned the Programme to the University of Nicosia. The programme is fully funded by the Ministry of Education, Sport and Youth.

➤ ***«Hesperides» Preventive Programme***

The Programme concerns the provision of psychological, social and educational support to pupils attending Evening Schools and Evening Technical Schools. The target groups are twenty pupils of the Evening Gymnasium, Lyceum and Technical and Vocational Education School, members of the families of the pupils, as well as the teachers of the schools. The implementation of the Programme is the responsibility of the Cyprus National Addictions Authority, which after an open tender procedure assigned the Programme to the Association for the Prevention and Combating of Domestic Violence (SPAVO). The programme is fully funded by the Ministry of Education, Sport and Youth.

➤ ***Preventive Preparatory Apprenticeship (PA) Intervention Programme in the Districts of Lefkosia, Larnaka, Lemesos and Pafos***

The programme is an action dealing with early school dropouts and the marginalization of the 14 - 16 years old pupils. The main objective of the programme is to provide a safe reintegration of Preparatory Apprentice teenagers into the school environment through the framing and support of themselves and their families with the ultimate goal of providing a safety net against various social risks and marginalization.

The PA provides a safe and supportive framework to upgrade the basic learning and soft skills of the learners, strengthen the goal-setting mechanism, and support them to believe in themselves and their skills, as well as improve their self-esteem by choosing and implementing correct and healthy choices in their life. PA's target groups are:

1. Pupils of the Preparatory Apprenticeship
2. Family members of the pupils
3. Teachers of the Preparatory Apprenticeship
4. Special social scientists of the Preparatory Apprenticeship.

The programme provides training of instructors and specialists, organization of afternoon / summer activities for the learners, organization of creativity workshops, sports and educational activities for the learners as well as psychosocial support and coverage of basic material needs of the learners and their families. Responsible for the implementation of the Programme is the "National Addictions Authority Cyprus", which after an open tender process assigned the Programme to the "Association for the Prevention and Handling of Violence in the Family" (SPAVO). The programme is entirely financed by the Cyprus Ministry of Education, Sport and Youth.

➤ ***Supply of sports equipment to pupils belonging to vulnerable groups***

The Action is included in the Memorandum of Cooperation between the Cyprus Addiction Treatment Authority and the Cyprus Sports Organization, through the "Tackling Addiction to Legal and Illegal Substances" Plan. For the 2022 – 2023 and 2024-24 school year, thirty athletes were supported who belong to: (a) vulnerable population groups and (b) sport clubs, which take part in the World Championships of the Cypriot Sports Federation, recognized by the CMO.

- Please elaborate and, where appropriate, indicate the legal and policy measures taken:

- What challenges were encountered in realizing the right to education of students from poor households? If needed, brief quantitative information may be added.

2. Progress made with respect to implementing the right to education across all levels and forms of education

2.1 Early childhood care and education

For reference: Early childhood care and education (ECCE) is not explicitly provided for in the Convention/Recommendation. However, the international community has increasingly recognized the importance of ECCE over the years. The Committee on the Rights of the Child initially recognized “the right to education during early childhood as beginning at birth” (General Comment No. 7). This became more explicit with the 2010 Moscow Framework for Action and Cooperation³⁷ and more recently, the Tashkent Declaration and Commitments to Action for Transforming Early Childhood Care and Education³⁸. In the current context of the Education 2030 agenda, under SDG target 4.2, states have now committed to “the provision of at least one year of free and compulsory pre-primary education”.

- Please indicate the measures taken to ensure access to quality ECCE (*several items may be ticked*):

☐ Prior to pre-primary education, ECCE services are free

☒ Prior to pre-primary education, ECCE services are affordable

☒ ECCE services are accessible on a non-discriminatory basis

☒ ECCE services respect a child’s need for early cognitive and social development, foundational learning, responsive care, nutrition, health, safety, protection, and play.

- Please elaborate further on the measures taken:

³⁷ Which states that “ECCE is part of the right to education and the main foundation for holistic human development”.
³⁸ Which commits states to “Enhance policy and legal frameworks to ensure that the right to education includes ECCE”

- Is compulsory and free of charge pre-primary education available?

✓ **Pre-primary education is compulsory.** Please provide the age of enrolment and duration:

Children aged 5 years can be enrolled in compulsory pre-primary education according to the Compulsory Education Law, one year and four months before they attend primary education. For the school year 2024-2025, according to the decision of the Council of Ministers, pre-primary education is compulsory if before the 1st September, a child is 4 years and 6 months old. Gradually compulsory pre-primary education will be extended from the age of four.

☐ Pre-primary education is **not** compulsory.

✓ **Pre-primary education is free of charge for all.** Please provide the duration and indicate the extent to which it is free:

Pre-Primary education is compulsory and free for children aged 4 ⁶/₁₂ years old and above who will be enrolled in the school year 2024-2025 in public Pre-Primary schools. Younger children aged between 3 to 4 ⁶/₁₂ that are approved and enrolled in public Pre-Primary schools pay fees, which are defined by the Ministry of Education, Sport and Youth, in cooperation with the Ministry of Finance.

☐ Pre-primary education is **not** free.

- Please list the relevant laws and policies. Where applicable, provide information on the direct costs (e.g., enrolment fees and tuition fees) and indirect costs (e.g., schools supplies, uniforms, transport and compulsory levies on parents). Brief quantitative information may be added.

- What challenges were encountered in realizing early childhood care and education and pre-primary education?

☐ Limited access

☐ Poor learning outcomes

☐ Issues of equity and inclusion

☐ Low number of professionally trained educators

☐ Poor quality programmes

☐ Lack of support to families

☐ Other:

- Please elaborate. Brief quantitative information may be added.

2.2 Primary and secondary education

For reference: Article/Paragraph 4(a) of the Convention/Recommendation provides for universal primary and secondary education. In the context of the Education 2030 agenda, SDG target 4.1 calls on

States to provide “12 years of free, publicly funded, inclusive, equitable, quality primary and secondary education – of which at least nine years are compulsory.”

Primary education

- Please provide the age of enrolment and duration of primary education:

According to the decision of the Council of Ministers, a child who has completed the age of 6 years before the 1st of September of the enrolment year must enrol at a primary school. The duration of primary education is six years (ages 6-12).

- Is primary education compulsory and free of charge?

✓ **Primary education is compulsory**

☐ Primary education is **not** compulsory.

✓ **Primary education is free of charge.**

☐ Primary education is **not** free.

- Please list the relevant laws and policies. Where applicable, provide information on the direct costs (e.g., enrolment fees and tuition fees) and indirect costs (e.g., exam fees, schools supplies, uniforms, transport and compulsory levies on parents). Brief quantitative information may be added.

Compulsory Education Law 2024

- What challenges were encountered in realizing primary education?

☐ Limited access

☐ Issues of equity and inclusion

☐ High dropout rates

☐ Poor quality programmes

☐ Other:

☐ Poor learning outcomes in:

Foundation literacy

Numeracy

Social and emotional learning

Others

☐ Disparity in learning outcomes

☐ Low number of professionally trained teachers

- Please elaborate. Brief quantitative information may be added.

Secondary education

In this part, please provide information on the general availability and accessibility to all of secondary education, including technical and vocational secondary education and training.

- Please provide the age of enrolment and duration of lower secondary education:

Students enrol in lower secondary schools (gymnasiums) at the age of 12. And the duration of the lower secondary education is three (3) years.

- Please provide the age of enrolment and duration of upper secondary education:

Upper Secondary Education (both Upper Secondary General Education and Upper Secondary Technical and Vocational Education) lasts for three years and is provided to pupils aged 15 to 18 free of charge.

- Is lower and upper secondary education compulsory and free of charge?

- ✓ **Lower secondary education is compulsory.**
- ☐ Lower secondary education is **not** compulsory.
- ✓ **Lower secondary education is free of charge.**
- ☐ Lower secondary education is **not** free of charge.
- ☐ Upper secondary education is compulsory.
- ✓ **Upper secondary education is not compulsory.**
- ✓ **Upper secondary education is free of charge**
- ☐ Upper secondary education is **not** free of charge.

- Please list the relevant laws and policies. Where applicable, provide information on the direct costs (e.g., enrolment fees and tuition fees) and indirect costs (e.g., exam fees, schools supplies, uniforms, transport and compulsory levies on parents). Brief quantitative information may be added.

Primary and Secondary Education Law of 1993 for the compulsory primary and lower secondary free education.

According to the above-mentioned law all books are provided to all students for free. Transportation of students to school is also free (for those who live in remote areas) or subsidized. There are no fees for the end of the year exams in lower or upper secondary education but exam fees apply for the University Entrance Exams, but are voided for students of low socioeconomic background.

- Please indicate whether the legal minimum age for employment is aligned with the end of compulsory education:

For reference: The employment laws and those related to compulsory education are interdependent and mutually reinforce each other. If the minimum age of employment is below that of compulsory

education, the child is at risk of dropping out of school to work and therefore not completing compulsory education. On the other hand, if compulsory education is lower than the minimum age of employment, once the child has completed compulsory education, the door is open to child exploitation and the violation of labour laws.

✓ Yes No

- Please provide reference to the relevant laws and provisions and indicate how the provision is enforced:

According to the Law for young people's employability, students younger than 15 years of age are not allowed to work. The Ministry of Education prosecutes parents of students younger than 15 years of age who do not attend school.

- What challenges were encountered in realizing secondary education?

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Limited access | ☐ Poor learning outcomes |
| ☐ Issues of equity and inclusion | ☐ Low readiness of primary graduates |
| ☐ High dropout rates | ☐ Low number of professionally trained teachers |
| ☐ Poor quality programmes | |
| ☐ Other: | |

- Please elaborate. Brief quantitative information may be added.

2.3 Higher education

For reference: Article/Paragraph 4(a) of the Convention/Recommendation provides for higher education. Ensuring higher education is essential to achieve SDG4, both targets 4.3³⁹, and target 4.4⁴⁰. Article 4 of the Convention requires states to make "higher education equally accessible to all on the basis of individual capacity". Article 13 of the International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights (1966) further adds that this should be pursued by "every appropriate means, and in particular by the progressive introduction of free education". Higher education includes technical and vocational education and training.

- Please indicate efforts made to ensure that higher education, including technical, vocation education and training, is equally accessible to all on the basis of individual capacity and/or is available free of charge (*several items may be ticked*):

³⁹ Which calls on states to "ensure equal access for all women and men to affordable and quality technical, vocational and tertiary education, including university".

⁴⁰ Which recommends to "substantially increase the number of youth and adults who have relevant skills, including technical and vocational skills, for employment, decent jobs and entrepreneurship".

- ✓ **Higher education is free of charge**
- ✓ **Higher education is accessible on the basis of individual capacity (as assessed by reference to relevant qualifications and experience)**
- ✓ **Higher education is accessible through financial incentives and scholarships**
- ☐ Higher education is accessible through positive or affirmative action measures
- ✓ **Higher education is accessible through credit transfer system between states**
- ✓ **Higher education allows for multiple and flexible learning pathways (flexible entry and re-entry, recognition, validation, and accreditation of knowledge and skills acquired through non-formal and informal education).**
- ☐ Other:

- Please list the relevant laws and policies. Where applicable, provide information on the direct costs (e.g., enrolment fees and tuition fees) and indirect costs (e.g., exam fees, university supplies, transport, accommodation). Brief quantitative information may be added.

In April 2017, the Cyprus Agency of Quality Assurance and Accreditation of Higher Education accredited the Post-Secondary Institutes of Vocational Education and Training as a Public School of Higher Vocational Education and Training (PSHVET) and classified their programmes at level 5 of EQF and ISCED. Successful completion of the programmes leads to the acquisition of a Diploma of Higher Vocational Education and Training (120 ECTS).

The operation of the PSHVET is co-financed by the EU and the Republic of Cyprus, in the context of the Project “Development of Technical and Vocational Education and Training”. Its objective is to contribute to tackling the problem of skills mismatch and youth unemployment, since the programmes offered have been especially designed to be relevant to labour market needs and respond to the requirements of emerging economic sectors and the rapid development of technology. The programmes offered address people of all ages who are secondary education graduates (both graduates of Upper Secondary General Education and graduates of Upper Secondary Technical and Vocational Education). By attending the Public School of Higher VET, adult learners of all ages have the opportunity to acquire, improve, or upgrade their technical and vocational education, as well as their skills and competences, thus becoming better qualified and more competitive to enter the labour market. Attendance is free of charge, facilitating adults, often unemployed, to access Higher VET programmes and acquire an accredited Diploma. The duration of the programmes is two years, on a 5-day basis. The programmes include practical training in industry and businesses/enterprises, related to the field of study. Practical training in industry lasts for six weeks per academic year, i.e. twelve weeks of practical training in companies in total per programme. There are five campuses of the School, operating in all major towns of Cyprus, in order to facilitate access to the programmes.

Free Higher Education is provided for undergraduate studies to all citizens of the Republic of Cyprus at public Higher Education Institutions (HEI) in Cyprus on the basis of results in the Pancyprian Examinations, i.e. the entrance examinations to public universities and institutions of higher education organised centrally by the Department of Higher Education of the Ministry of Education, Sports and Youth (MESY). The Private HEIs in Cyprus charge tuition fees for both undergraduate and postgraduate programs. The fees vary depending on the program and the level of study.

The Cyprus State Scholarship Foundation provides scholarships to citizens of the Republic of Cyprus and/or citizens from member States of the European Union for undergraduate and postgraduate studies (Master's level) for full-time attendance in Cyprus or abroad based on merit and, mainly, on socioeconomic criteria in order to support students from lower income backgrounds. Financial support is also provided to students (especially those from disadvantaged backgrounds), in several ways. Indicatively, a 'student grant' can be awarded to undergraduate and graduate students studying at accredited programmes of study in order to support their studies in Cyprus and/or abroad. The 'student allowance' is a targeted need-based grant to cover living expenses, books, rental and computer purchasing of undergraduate students. Student grants and allowances target students from the following groups: special education needs, disabilities, refugee status, low socio-economic status, family background (e.g. single parent, from care homes). The grant provider is the Student Welfare Service, established under the Ministry of Finance, which is responsible for both the 'student grant' and the 'student allowance'.

At an institutional level, the HEIs, both Public and Private, offer scholarships based on performance and socio-economic status. They also provide other help based on socio-economic criteria, as inclusion to accommodation in the Halls of Residence of the Public Universities, as well as free meals. Private HEIs offer a range of financial aid options and scholarships to help students cover their living expenses and any additional costs.

Additionally, some HEIs offer work-study programs that allow students to work part-time on campus to earn money and gain work experience while studying.

Higher Education in Cyprus is accessible through the European Credit Transfer and Accumulation System (ECTS), which facilitates student mobility and academic recognition across different institutions, both within Cyprus, Europe and internationally. This system allows students to transfer credits earned at one institution to another, thereby supporting their academic progress and providing flexibility in their education journey and it is widely implemented across HEIs in Cyprus. Each course or module is assigned a specific number of ECTS credits based on the required workload to complete it. ECTS credits earned at one institution can be transferred to another, provided that the receiving institution recognizes the courses as part of the student's program.

Beyond ECTS, participation of HEIs in programs like Erasmus+ and national frameworks like the Cyprus Qualifications Framework further enhance the effectiveness of the credit transfer system, providing students with greater flexibility and opportunities in their Higher Education pursuits.

➤ ***Erasmus+ Program***

Cyprus participates actively in the Erasmus+ program, through which students can study abroad at partner institutions for a period of time, with the credits earned during this period being transferred back to their home institution.

➤ ***Bilateral Agreements***

Many Cypriot HEIs have bilateral agreements with HEIs abroad, allowing for the transfer of credits. These agreements often outline the specific courses and programs covered, ensuring that students can seamlessly continue their studies.

➤ ***Cyprus Qualifications Framework (CyQF)***

The CyQF is aligned with the European Qualifications Framework (EQF), ensuring that qualifications and credits are compatible and comparable across Europe. This alignment facilitates the recognition and transfer of credits within Cyprus and across European Institutions.

- What challenges were encountered in realizing higher education?

- ☐ Limited access
- ☐ Issues of equity and inclusion
- ☐ Poor quality programmes
- ☐ Poor learning outcomes
- ☐ Low number of professionally trained professors
- ☐ Insufficient mechanisms to ensure smooth transition from secondary to tertiary

✓ **Other:**

Challenges posed by the ongoing Turkish occupation of Cyprus

The so called “universities”, operating in the area of the Republic of Cyprus which remains under Turkish military occupation since 1974, are unlawfully operating bodies, since they have not been established nor have they been operating under the relevant Laws and Regulations of the Republic of Cyprus on Higher Education. In addition, they operate under the purported “law” of the so called “Turkish Republic of Northern Cyprus” (“TRNC”) which, according to International law, including the relevant United Nations Security Council resolutions, is an illegal entity not recognized by the international community with the sole exception of Turkey. Therefore, these institutions, as well as the “qualifications” they award, are not recognized.

- Please elaborate. Brief quantitative information may be added.

2.4 Adult education and alternative learning

For reference: Article/Paragraph 4(c) of the Convention/Recommendation provides for adult education and alternative learning. While SDG4 aims to “ensure inclusive and equitable quality education and promote lifelong learning opportunities for all”, target 4.6 specifically calls on states to “ensure that all youth and a substantial proportion of adults, both men and women, achieve literacy and numeracy”. Furthermore, under target 4.4, states are called “to increase and diversify learning opportunities, using a wide range of education and training modalities, so that all youth and adults, especially girls and women, can acquire relevant knowledge, skills and competencies for decent work and life.”

- Please indicate the measures taken to establish a system of continuing education and equitable access to learning and training opportunities (several items may be ticked):

- ☐ Provision of education for persons who have not received or completed the whole period of their primary education
- ☐ Provision of literacy programmes
- ✓ **Provision of continuous learning (such as learning programmes to develop knowledge, skills, abilities, or competencies for personal and professional development)**
- ✓ **Provision of free of charge learning opportunities**
- ✓ **Provision of professional training including reskilling and upskilling programmes**
- ☐ Recognition, validation and certification of non-formal and informal learning

✓ **Provision of free of charge career guidance and counselling**

✓ **Lifelong learning entitlements including learning accounts, vouchers, etc.**

☐ Other:

- Please elaborate further on the measures taken:

In the context of the operation of the Lifelong Learning Programmes of Vocational Education and Training, the Department of Secondary Technical and Vocational Education and Training offers one-year and three-year training programmes in order to respond to the increasing need for continuous up-skilling and re-skilling throughout an individual's working life. The objective of these programmes is to offer lifelong learning opportunities for education and training to employed or unemployed adults, including migrants, in order to be able to respond more effectively to the contemporary demands of the labour market and enhance their integration in society.

The programmes operate on the premises of Technical and Vocational Schools of Education and Training in all major Government controlled areas of Cyprus. Learners pay limited fees approved by the Council of Ministers for attending these programmes. Migrants who are asylum seekers can attend these programmes free of charge.

The CyLLLS for the years 2021-2027 recognising the need for further developments in the area of establishing validation and assessment processes, introducing quality standards for non-formal learning programmes, and forming links between validation arrangements and credit systems. Although, Cyprus has not set an official framework for the recognition and validation of non-formal and informal learning, several developments took place during the last years, such as the Human Resource Development Authority's System of Vocational Qualifications (SVQs), as well as the System for the Assessment and Accreditation of Training. Also, programmes run and managed by the several departments of the MESY (Ministry of Education, Sport and Youth) address the needs of various target groups and ensure equal access to the provide programmes for all adults. These programs, covering both the formal and the non-formal sector, include Adult Education Centres, State Institutes of Further Education (KIE), Evening Schools (second-chance schools), Lifelong Learning Programs of VET, and the Public School of Higher VET (PSIVET, also known as "MIEEK").

- What challenges were encountered in realizing adult learning and education?

☐ Limited access

☐ Limited funding

☐ Issues of equity and inclusion

☐ Poor learning outcomes

☐ Poor quality programmes

☐ Low number of professionally trained educators

☐ Other:

Obstacles adults face in their participation in lifelong learning.

- Please elaborate. Brief quantitative information may be added.

Adults face several challenges that hinder their participation in lifelong learning. During the preparation of the CyLLLS, major stakeholders identified several key barriers, including the cost of programmes, particularly for unemployed individuals and vulnerable social groups. Other significant challenges include the delivery methods of these programmes, which may not be flexible enough to accommodate diverse needs, the timing of provision that often conflicts with family and work obligations and the difficulty in accessing clear and comprehensive information about available learning opportunities.

3. Quality education provision and learning environment

For reference: Articles/Paragraphs 2, 4(b) and 5(b) of the Convention/Recommendation provide for quality education. Quality education is fundamental to achieve all targets of SDG4. It is also particularly highlighted in SDG target 4.a that recommends states to “build and upgrade education facilities that are child, disability and gender sensitive and provide safe, non-violent, inclusive and effective learning environments for all”.

3.1 General measures

- Please indicate whether the legal or regulatory framework lays out the conditions and minimum education standards for the establishment and functioning of public education institutions regarding:

- ✓ **State monitoring and inspections**
- ☐ Health and sanitation
- ✓ **Safety (children learn in a safe environment free from violence or harassment, including school-related gender-based violence (in and around schools))**
- ✓ **Infrastructure**
- ✓ **Curriculum**
- ✓ **Student-teacher ratio**
- ☐ School fees (if relevant)
- ☐ Other

- Please elaborate on each of the measures taken:

You may include information on policies, protocols or codes of conduct.

The Ministry of Education, Sport and Youth (MESY) has designed and developed the National Strategy for Preventing and addressing School Violence (COSV), which has a four-year timeframe of implementation (2018 -2024). According to its role and responsibilities, and based on the aforementioned Strategy, the COSV has developed and implemented actions that aim to prevent and address bullying and violence at schools. The COSV provides support to school units for the implementation of actions and programmes aimed at improving the school climate, with the ultimate aim of reducing violence at schools. These programmes, run on an annual basis and are school-based, are the "Conflict Resolution - School Mediation" and the "Recognition and Management of School Bullying". The COSV supports schools in the

implementation of anti-bullying programmes, which deal with recognizing, preventing and combating bullying. With "Conflict Resolution - School Mediation" schools are encouraged to find effective ways of resolving pupils' conflicts as well as alternative ways of managing conflict situations at school. In 2023, 104 schools were supported and 4008 teachers and 300 parents were trained by COSV.

Guidelines on how to handle conflicts or bullying were produced and disseminated at the training courses. Also, educational material to assist teachers on how to undertake activities with children to enhance their competences needed for prevention and management of school violence was produced and disseminated. The curriculum of this material includes activities to enhance anger management, team building, empathy, emotional intelligence, social and communicative skills, tolerance, acceptance of diversity, mediation skills, anti-bullying skills, conflict management etc.

The COSV also monitored a national-level research that investigates the phenomenon of violence at schools. The research aims to collect data about violence in education, from all schools of all levels in Cyprus, for three consecutive years, with the participation of teachers, parents and students.

Moreover, the COSV collects data concerning good practices for the prevention of violence in schools, it evaluates these practices, and it organizes an annual conference where the best practices are awarded, thus receiving visibility and outreach. It also collaborates with other stakeholders involved in preventing and responding to school violence. Additionally, COSV organizes school based seminars related to the prevention and management of violence and delinquency. During the school year 2022-2023, 25 schools (2 kindergartens, 21 primary schools and 2 secondary schools) received such training and support.

In addition, the COSV participates as a partner in the Erasmus+ KA3 project titled "SAFER: Social competences and Fundamental Rights for preventing bullying (including on-line bullying)" (December 2020-November 2023). This project aims to experiment with the innovative method of "Whole School and Community Approach" in preventing and combating bullying.

Additionally to the above-mentioned actions, an Emergency Intervention Team (EIT) is established within the MESY and its role is to support schools, upon request, in managing serious incidents or occurrences of violence and delinquency within the school environment. The EIT works to strengthen the school unit in developing and implementing a plan that includes educational and administrative actions aimed, through a holistic approach, at resolving the problem. The EIT cooperates with the managements of the school units and the teachers, the Counseling and Vocational Education Teacher for Secondary Education, the relevant Educational Psychologist, the relevant Inspector, the parents/guardians association and other services, where necessary (e.g. Social Services, etc.) for the design and implementation of the Action Plan.

- What challenges were encountered in realizing quality education?

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Non-supportive or inadequate learning environments | ☐ Low quality educational infrastructure and materials |
| ☐ Violence in schools | ☐ Inadequate parental support to education |
| ☐ Cost of education | ☐ Long distances to schools |
| ☐ Conflicts or crises | |
| ☐ Other: | |

- Please elaborate. Brief quantitative information may be added.

3.2 Education personnel

For reference: Article/Paragraph 4(d) of the Convention/Recommendation provides for the education personnel. This corresponds to SDG target 4.c which is entirely devoted to the teaching profession as it calls on states to “substantially increase the supply of qualified teachers”.

- Please indicate the measures taken to improve the teaching and working conditions of education personnel, especially teaching staff at all levels and regarding the training for the teaching profession (several items may be ticked):

- ☒ **Teacher training is provided without discrimination.**
- ☒ **Teachers’ average salaries are competitive or at least comparable to those paid in other professions requiring similar or equivalent qualifications (at all levels).**
- ☒ **Initial training and continuous professional development are provided.**
- ☒ **Minimum standards and qualifications required for the teaching profession.**
- ☐ Measures taken to strengthen the social status and attractiveness of the teaching profession.
- ☐ Measures taken to promote diversity in the teaching workforce, including to redress gender imbalances at different levels of education.
- ☒ **Establishment of performance monitoring systems.**
- ☐ Measures taken to increase women in leadership positions in education.
- ☐ Other:

- Please elaborate on each of the measures taken:

The minimum standards and qualifications required for the teaching profession of every level (primary, secondary, vocational education) in Cyprus is holding at least a bachelor’s degree. Teachers’ average salaries are competitive, comparable and in some case above average to those paid in other professions requiring similar or equivalent qualifications (at all levels).

Teacher training is provided in Cyprus without discrimination by the Cyprus Pedagogical Institute (CPI), one the Directorates of the Ministry of Education, Sport and Youth (MESY). According to the Council of Ministers Decision (August 2015, July 2017), the CPI is the official department of the MESY which runs the professional learning of teachers. CPI’s mission is the design and implementation of continuous professional learning of teachers at all levels, the setting of framework for the teacher competences and the promotion of horizontal issues of educational priority, improving the content and effectiveness of the

education provided in accordance with the wider international, European, and local context.

Since 2015, a unified policy was introduced by the MESY concerning the professional learning of teachers. The policy designates CPI as the Official Body for Professional Learning of in-service teachers. At the same time, the CPI enhance Professional Learning of teachers via different methodologies (inquiry-based methodologies).

Initial training for teachers is offered by the Universities. Initial Pedagogical Training for secondary teachers is compulsory by legislation and it is offered by the University of Cyprus. As regards continuous professional development teachers in Cyprus have opportunities for professional learning through mandatory and optional seminars and workshops offered by the Ministry (Departments of Education or/and Cyprus Pedagogical Institute). Mandatory seminars and workshops, offered during the working hours of the teachers, concern issues that are of high priority for the Ministry (e.g. Teaching children with migrant background, Curriculum changes) and courses addressed to specific target group of teachers (e.g. newly promoted school heads and deputy-heads). Optional opportunities for professional learning are also offered by the Ministry, stakeholder organisations and universities.

Regarding the establishment of performance monitoring system, reform measures that focus on educators will be completed with the New Evaluation System for educators and educational practice, which is now in its final stages of development. In the proposal for the new evaluation system, formative assessment from the outset is being put in place for teachers, with varying input designed for different stages of a teacher's career. A new promotion position of Senior Teacher is suggested which enables teachers to stay in the classroom but with less teaching time to enable the person in that role to support others. The role of the school head in the assessment process becomes more significant. Inspectors who have the dual role of assessing and counselling teachers will have to undertake one of those roles for a maximum of four years. The effectiveness of the assessors and the whole system will be evaluated by a post-evaluation process.

- What challenges were encountered in the education personnel?

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Shortages of teaching staff | ☐ Low quality educational infrastructure and materials |
| ☐ Lack of qualified, trained and motivated teaching staff | ☐ High student – teacher ratio |
| ☐ Lack of training centres | |
| ☐ Other: | |

- Please elaborate. Brief quantitative information may be added.

3.3 Respect for human rights and fundamental freedoms

For reference: Article/Paragraph 5(1)(a) of the Convention/Recommendation provides for the respect for human rights and fundamental freedoms. This is covered under SDG target 4.7.⁴¹ Please note that this section contributes to the general monitoring of Article/Paragraph 5(1)(a) of the Convention/Recommendation and that the future consultation on the 1974 Recommendation concerning Education for International Understanding, Co-operation and Peace and Education relating to Human Rights and Fundamental Freedoms // 2023 Recommendation on [...] will be used specifically for monitoring SDG4 indicator 4.7.1.

- Please indicate the national efforts taken in directing education to the full development of the human personality and the strengthening of respect for human rights and fundamental freedoms (several items may be ticked):

☐ Curriculum includes human rights education.

☒ **Educational and/or extracurricular activities are organized on human rights education.**

☐ Other:

- Please elaborate on each of the measures taken:

⁴¹

Which calls on states to “ensure that all learners acquire the knowledge and skills needed to promote sustainable development, including, among others, through education for sustainable development and sustainable lifestyles, human rights, gender equality, promotion of a culture of peace and non-violence, global citizenship and appreciation of cultural diversity and of culture’s contribution to sustainable development”.

The Ministry of Education, Sports and Youth (MESY), in 2014-2015, represented Cyprus as a partner country in the Council of Europe's Pilot Project titled "Teaching controversial issues – developing effective training for teachers and school leaders". The aim of the project was to assess how the teaching of contentious/controversial issues, including issues related to religion and belief, can support education for democratic citizenship and human rights. MESY officials participated in pan-European conferences where they presented the results and their experience from Cyprus's participation in the project. A major product of the project was the "Teaching Controversial Topics" guide, a publication of the Council of Europe. The material approaches issues related to religion and belief, among others, through teaching strategies and pedagogical methods from the context of human rights education. The manual continues to be the basis for numerous trainings that have been carried out by the Cyprus Pedagogical Institute (CPI) since 2014 and continue to this day.

Furthermore, the CPI continues to support teachers and schools, by providing training workshops for the implementation of the anti-racist policy and by organising conferences on issues of racism and human rights. In addition, it supports schools on relevant issues through the Professional Learning Programme, organises in-service teachers' training seminars, on a school basis, as well as a series of seminars where teachers can attend in the afternoon, on an optional basis. Indicatively, during 2023, the following in-service seminars were offered by, for both primary and secondary education:

- "Nail" or defender? Ways to empower pupils as bystanders in incidents of school violence and bullying
- Recognition and management of incidents of school bullying: Policy of the Ministry of Education and Culture
- Addressing and managing bullying behaviors in the school environment
- Anti-racist policy of the Ministry of Education: Stages of implementation and challenges in the management of racist incidents
- Conflict management in the school environment
- Peer support group
- School delinquency and school bullying - Managing crises and conflicts around issues of social class, gender and ethnicity
- Prevention and management of homophobia and transphobia at school
- School Conflicts: Prevention and management
- Teacher empowerment techniques on school bullying.

3.4 Non-state actors in education

For reference: Articles/Paragraphs 2(c) and 5(1)(b) of the Convention/Recommendation provide for non-state education provision⁴².

- Please indicate the measures taken to ensure the provision of quality non-state education (several items may be ticked):

⁴² Private, faith-based, NGOs, community actors.

✓ **Legal provisions prohibiting discrimination on the grounds listed by the Convention/Recommendation⁴³ explicitly apply to non-state educational institutions. Please specify:**

Legal provisions prohibiting any kind of discrimination that apply for public schools also apply in non-state (private) schools.

✓ **Policies aim to guarantee that the development of non-state education does not generate discrimination and that non-state actors offer a relevant alternative (without supplanting public education). Please specify:**

Non-state actors in education do give students alternatives in assessment and university entrance exams but at the same time the application of fees can be considered some form of discrimination.

✓ **Legal provisions provide for the rights of the parents /legal guardians for providing religious and moral education for their children. Please specify:**

Providing religious education is not included in the non-state school obligations.

☐ **Legal or regulatory framework lays out the conditions and minimum education standards for the establishment and functioning of non-state educational institutions. Please specify what is covered:**

✓ **Registration**

✓ **State monitoring and inspections**

✓ **Qualifications of teachers**

☐ Health and sanitation

☐ Safety (children learn in a safe environment free from violence or harassment, including school-related gender-based violence (in and around schools))

✓ **Infrastructure**

✓ **Curriculum**

☐ Student-teacher ratio

☐ School fees

✓ **School closures**

☐ Other

- Please elaborate:

⁴³ See: Article/Paragraph 1(1).

All of the above are regulated by the Law for Private Schools, passed in 2019 and amended in 2020.

- What challenges were encountered in non-state education provision?

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Low quality educational infrastructure and materials | ☐ Issues in terms of equity and inclusion |
| ☐ Low number of professionally trained teachers | ✓ Weak government regulatory and monitoring capacity |
| ☐ High student – teacher ratio | |
| ☐ Other: | |

- Please elaborate. Brief quantitative information may be added.

3.5 Digital education

Digital education is both an opportunity for enhancing access but also can lead to challenges in terms of quality education and inclusion⁴⁴.

- Please indicate the measures taken to ensure the provision of quality digital education (several items may be ticked):

✓ **Digital technology use in education is provided for in the legal framework.**

Please indicate the relevant text and provisions:

Digital technology is included in the school curriculum that is approved by the Council of Ministers.

✓ **Core legislations, policies, strategies or plans for the management, privacy, security, storage, transfer, use, and sharing of education data internally and externally to ensure the right to privacy of learners and education stakeholders (e.g., informed consent, transparent usage policies, etc.)**

✓ **Regulatory framework establishes minimum education standards for digital education to which all actors in education must comply.**

✓ **Measures to remove barriers to accessing digital content⁴⁵, including ensuring access to curriculum-aligned digital content available on free, public, multi-modal national platforms; high-quality content is available in core subjects, official national language(s), and designed with inclusive features to assist learners with disabilities.**

⁴⁴ Please see General Comment No. 25 (2021) of the Committee on the Rights of the Child which covers children's right to education in relation to the digital environment.

⁴⁵ Lack of internet connection, basic infrastructure or devices.

✓ **Digital skills incorporated into pre- and in-service teacher and leadership training curricula to create a culture of digital innovation and growth anchored in equity and inclusion that enables ongoing professional development for existing and emerging staff.**

✓ **Future-ready skills (including digital skills, data and AI competencies, critical thinking, etc.) integrated into formal curriculum at all levels of education**

□ Measures address the digital divide, including ensuring access to reliable electricity, meaningful internet connectivity at school and at home, devices suitable for learning and teaching, safe and sustainable software and secure platforms, and integrated education data systems.

✓ **A well-established, sustainable, and cost-effective budget secured from a range of funding sources and intersectoral cooperation, supported by impact focused reporting linked to regional strategic goals.**

- Please elaborate on each of the measures taken:

The syllabus of Computer Science applies to all Cypriot pupils in the same way without discrimination. During the past few years, the syllabi of all Information Technology (IT) courses taught in Secondary Education have been updated in order to meet European standards and current trends. Teaching of these courses at the Gymnasium and Lyceum aims to engage pupils in meaningful learning using the computer as a problem-solving tool. In all Lycea, depending on the curriculum needs, there are 130 IT labs for the teaching of all computer science courses. Each lab contains 18 computers and a printer. In all Gymnasia, depending on the curriculum needs, there are 181 IT labs with 13 computers and a printer per lab. Furthermore, a video projector is installed in all IT labs. The video projector is connected to the instructor's computer. All computers in each IT lab are interconnected to form a local network and are connected to the Internet via an ADSL line. In all Gymnasia, the course of Informatics is compulsory and is taught two periods per week in each of the three classes. Part of the curriculum covers four basic modules of the international standard European Computer Driving License (ECDL).

The Cyprus Pedagogical Institute (CPI) implements several actions aiming to contribute to the development of digital skills for in service teachers and students, guided by national and EU digital strategies and based on European digital competence frameworks and tools. CPI's actions include: the Digital Competence Development for Educators Programme, which follows a distance learning approach and methodology utilizing CPI's eLearning Environment, annual educational programs (Innovative schools and Teacher coaches, Young Coaches for the Internet, eSafe Schools, Recording Memory, Student Web Radio), seminars, workshops, contests (Radio and Music Student Contest "Make it Heard", CyberSafety Video Production Contest), conferences (Digital Education - Developments and pedagogical practices, Advancing Media Literacy in Education: Contemporary Approaches in Pedagogy), and pilot implementation of EU Projects such as Learning from the Extremes (PPPA Grant Agreement No.LC-01760255/10105266) and Social Radio 2.0 - The European School Radio and Podcasting Community for Active Citizenship Education (KA2 Agreement No. 2020-1-PL01-KA201-081838).

- What challenges were encountered in digital education provision (check all that apply)?

- ☐ Lack of quality, curriculum-aligned digital teaching and learning content that supports flexible learning and teaching pathways
- ☐ Lack of equity and inclusion in digital learning solutions
- ☐ inadequate safety measures and IT support to respond to issues of child online safety or reduce cyber security risks
- ☐ Other:
- ☐ Limited access to internet and/or electricity
- ✓ **Limited access to hardware (devices, chargers, etc.)**
- ☐ Difficulty in regulating the use of digital education solutions
- ☐ Difficulty in sustainably financing digital education solutions at national scale
- ☐ Lack of digital skills development for meaningful use of digital technology in teaching practice
- ☐ Disjointed or fragmented solutions that are not centrally systematized or regulated

- Please elaborate. Brief quantitative information may be added.

Limited access to hardware among refugees and migrant students.

4 Strengthening governance systems

For reference: The Education 2030 Framework for Action states "to ensure quality education and conditions for effective education outcomes, governments should strengthen education systems by instituting and improving appropriate, effective and inclusive governance and accountability mechanisms; quality assurance; management information systems; transparent and effective financing procedures and mechanisms; and institutional management arrangements, as well as ensure that robust, timely and accessible data are available" (para. 18).

- Please indicate the measures taken in terms of governance (several items may be ticked):

- ☐ Monitoring mechanisms to assess compliance with the right to education obligations, including through management information systems.
- ☐ Monitoring results are made public. [Please provide the link:](#)

- ☐ Monitoring processes are participatory, inclusive and regular.

✓ **Sector-wide and multisector approach is adopted to education governance.**

- ☐ Financial resources are effectively allocated to prioritise the provision of free, quality, public education and are adequately budgeted for in government plans.
- ☐ The decision-making process for the allocation of resources to education is transparent.

√ Ensuring crisis-sensitive and disaster risk-informed planning and programming, including the provision of quality education in emergencies.

√ There is a certain degree of decentralization in favour of local public authorities and autonomy for schools to ensure context relevance of their teaching.

- Please elaborate on each of the measures taken:

The Ministry of Education, Sport and Youth (MESY) is responsible for the preparation of educational bills, the implementation of educational policy, the management of education (development, monitoring and assessment of strategic goals and plans), the prescription of syllabi, curricula and textbooks, the maintenance and equipment (shared responsibility with local School Boards), the construction of school buildings, the professional development of teachers and the inspection of teachers and schools. The local School Boards are responsible for some financial management and infrastructure management of school buildings, including employment of cleaning and maintenance staff, dealing mostly with minor routine works. Teachers and headteachers are responsible for the selection of teaching methods, the organization of professional development activities within the school unit, based on their needs, the management of a small amount of money, for operational expenses and small repairs and for the development of the school's unified development plan, part of which is teachers' professional learning policy. As a result, the education system is highly centralized and the autonomy granted at the school level is limited.

- What challenges were encountered in terms of governance?

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Budgetary constraints | ☐ Absence of supportive/ inconsistent/obsolete legal and policy environment |
| ☐ Lack of involvement of relevant stakeholders and lack of cooperation/coordination at different levels | ☐ Lack or weakness of monitoring systems – including the lack of reliable data |
| ☐ Poor dialogue with teachers' trade unions | |
| ☐ Other: | |

- Please elaborate. Brief quantitative information may be added.

III. Methods used to draw the attention of the various authorities in the country to the instruments

For reference: UNESCO governing bodies have underlined the need for awareness raising. Given the importance of normative action at the national level, wide dissemination of the Convention must be ensured, with the support of National Commissions for UNESCO.

- Have activities been carried out to draw the attention of the various authorities of the country to the Convention/Recommendation and their provisions about the right to education and to raise awareness

of the principles of non-discrimination and equality of educational opportunities? (Several items may be ticked)

- ☐ Translation of the Convention/Recommendation into the national and possibly local languages
- ☐ Dissemination and advocacy of the core content of the Convention/Recommendation or the core principles of the right to education including through appropriate materials and resources
- ✓ **Activities undertaken or supported by the National Commission to promote non-discrimination and equality of educational opportunities and to foster debate on critical issues in relation to the rights enshrined in the instruments**
- ✓ **Other:**

UNESCO Associated Schools Network (ASPnet) in Cyprus

UNESCO Associated Schools in Cyprus are part of a global network dedicated to promoting peace, intercultural dialogue, and sustainable development through education. The 40 schools-members of the national network, engage in activities aligned with UNESCO's values, such as fostering cultural heritage awareness, human rights education, global citizenship education and education for sustainable development. Through various projects and initiatives, UNESCO Associated Schools in Cyprus contribute to a more inclusive and peaceful society. Among the main events of the network is the annual Pancyprian Student Forum of ASPnet, on a different topic every year, including presentations, panel discussions and workshops facilitated by NGOs and stakeholders active in the fields of human rights, cultural education and sustainable development. Other activities of the Network include conferences and awareness raising events on the occasion of International Days such as Human Rights Day, Day of Peace, Day Against Violence and Bullying at School and Migrants Day.

CINeDUCATION programme

Since 2018, Cyprus National Commission for UNESCO collaborates with the Cyprus Archaeological, Ethnographic and Historical Film Festival, to implement a series of activities related to film education and digital literacy. The program, entitled CINeDUCATION, provides capacity building workshops for young people in secondary or higher education institutions, for the production of short films on topics related to history and cultural heritage. The workshops are facilitated by archaeologists and professional film-makers, who provide training on the basic techniques to produce documentaries. The production phase is entirely implemented by students, under the supervision of educators and film professionals. So far, more than 70 films have been produced by youth teams through the programme. All films are screened publicly during the annual festival and compete for 3 awards and a special award, funded by the National Commission, for the best student film about cultural and/or natural heritage of Cyprus.

Innovation Camp in Cultural and Creative Industries

In 2022 the NGO Junior Achievement Cyprus and the Cyprus National Commission for UNESCO launched a joint annual programme for ASPnet students, an Innovation Camp on Cultural and Creative Industries. It is a one-day, intensive experience for high school students (aged 15-18 years), who work together to tackle a business challenge that simulates a real-world issue faced by professionals in cultural industries. Students receive extensive information, by keynote speakers and develop a proposal, under the guidance of professionals in the field of culture and entrepreneurship. The challenges discussed so far were related to cultural goods and services in the digital environment as well as traditional crafts marketing and transmission. In both cases, students were asked to consider in their proposals fair-trade principles. During the boot camp, in the process of solving actual problems faced by CCI, students cultivate a broad skill set, ranging from time

management to interpersonal and communication skills, which are all important for a holistic approach to problem-solving. Furthermore, during the Camp, students develop creative thinking, strengthen communication skills through teamwork and problem-solving and familiarize themselves with challenges in the field of culture.

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